Politics Subject Board
2025
Examiners' Report

Version History

Version 1	This version published on 9 October 2024

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Politics FHS 2025 – exam performance statistics by paper and school

No statistics are given for papers taken by 2 candidates or fewer. Only the mean and standard deviation are given for papers taken by 5 candidates or fewer.

Take up, mean, standard deviation, maximum and minimum mark

Paper by degree	Take up	Mean	St Dev	Max	Min
Advanced Paper in Theories of Justice	20	65.7	6.9	75	44
A15601P1	20	65.7	6.9	75	44
DMHP	3	71.0	5.3		
DPPE	17	64.8	6.8	74	44
British Politics and Government since 1900	92	65.1	5.3	81	50
A12720P1	92	65.1	5.3	81	50
DMHP	24	66.0	3.6	74	59
DPPE	68	64.8	5.7	81	50
Comparative Demographic Systems	5	61.4	8.6		
A12741P1	5	61.4	8.6		
DPPE	5	61.4	8.6		
Comparative Government	66	67.2	4.4	76	54
A12719P1	66	67.2	4.4	76	54

DMHP	8	66.1	3.5	72	60
DPPE	58	67.4	4.6	76	54
Comparative Political Economy	21	63.4	6.4	71	43
A17325P1	21	63.4	6.4	71	43
DMHP	1				
DPPE	20	63.2	6.5	71	43
Government and Politics of the United States	26	67.7	3.7	74	60
A12722P1	26	67.7	3.7	74	60
DMHP	6	66.5	3.5	70	60
DPPE	20	68.1	3.8	74	60
International Relations	151	65.3	9.2	81	0
A12731P1	151	65.3	9.2	81	0
DMHP	25	60.4	19.4	75	0
DPPE	126	66.2	5.0	81	54
International Relations in the Era of the Cold War	22	65.7	4.3	74	58
A12730P1	22	65.7	4.3	74	58
DMHP	6	63.7	3.6	70	60
DPPE	16	66.4	4.4	74	58
International Relations in the Era of Two World Wars	6	69.2	7.0	77	60

A12729P1	6	69.2	7.0	77	60
DMHP	4				
DPPE	2				
Marx and Marxism	17	67.8	4.0	75	62
A12734P1	17	67.8	4.0	75	62
DMHP	2				
DPPE	15	68.3	4.0	75	62
Modern British Government and Politics	36	66.9	3.8	74	56
A12721P1	36	66.9	3.8	74	56
DMHP	5	68.4	3.0		
DPPE	31	66.6	3.9	74	56
Political Sociology	83	64.8	7.2	81	37
A12737P1	82	65.1	6.6	81	38
DMHP	12	66.7	4.7	73	60
DPPE	70	64.9	6.8	81	38
A12737S1	1				
DPPE	1				
Political Thought: Bentham to Weber	10	68.6	4.6	76	63
A12733P1	10	68.6	4.6	76	63

DMHP	3	68.0	6.2		
DPPE	7	68.9	4.3	76	63
Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau	14	66.6	6.2	75	49
A12732P1	14	66.6	6.2	75	49
DMHP	4	62.8	10.7		
DPPE	10	68.1	2.9	73	63
Politics in China	23	61.5	7.7	77	49
A12743P1	23	61.5	7.7	77	49
DPPE	23	61.5	7.7	77	49
Politics in Europe	6	61.2	19.5	73	22
A12723P1	6	61.2	19.5	73	22
DPPE	6	61.2	19.5	73	22
Politics in Latin America	12	67.3	3.5	71	61
A12726P1	12				
DMHP	2				
DPPE	10	67.8	3.6	71	61
Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Union	17	65.4	3.9	74	60
A12724P1	17	65.4	3.9	74	60
DMHP	4	66.5	3.1		

DPPE	13	65.1	4.2	74	60
Politics in South Asia	9	71.2	3.5	77	66
A12727P1	9	71.2	3.5	77	66
DPPE	9	71.2	3.5	77	66
Politics in Sub-Saharan Africa	18	62.1	12.8	75	20
A12725P1	18	62.1	12.8	75	20
DMHP	4	56.0	24.3		
DPPE	14	63.9	7.9	75	45
Politics in the Middle East	30	65.4	12.7	73	0
A12728P1	30	65.4	12.7	73	0
DMHP	7	57.3	25.7	73	0
DPPE	23	67.9	2.6	72	61
Social Policy	29	66.8	3.9	75	57
A12740P1	29	66.8	3.9	75	57
DMHP	3	66.3	3.5		
DPPE	26	66.8	4.0	75	57
Sociological Theory	6	64.8	8.4	72	50
A12735P1	6				
DMHP	2				

DPPE	4	64.5	10.1		
Special Subject in Politics: Feminist Theory	28	65.8	9.9	76	22
A17606P1	28	65.8	9.9	76	22
DMHP	5	59.6	21.4		
DPPE	23	67.1	5.1	76	59
Special Subject in Politics: International Security and Conflict	48	67.3	5.7	77	43
A15594P1	48	67.3	5.7	77	43
DMHP	4	65.5	7.9		
DPPE	44	67.5	5.5	77	43
The Politics of the European Union	5				
A12744P1	5				
DMHP	2				
DPPE	3	64.3	6.0		
Theory of Politics	124	64.6	8.7	77	0
A15005P1	124	64.6	8.7	77	0
DMHP	18	59.5	16.2	77	0
DPPE	106	65.4	6.5	77	43
Thesis in Politics	16	62.5	17.8	79	0
A12746S1	16	62.5	17.8	79	0

DMHP	5	52.6	29.8		
DPPE	11	67.0	7.1	79	55
Grand Total	940	65.5	7.9	81	0

Bands of marks

Paper by degree	Take up	70-100 as %	60-69 as %	50-59 as %	40-49 as %	30-39 as %	<30 as %
Advanced Paper in Theories of Justice	20	35%	50%	10%	5%	0%	0%
A15601P1	20	35%	50%	10%	5%	0%	0%
DMHP	3						
DPPE	17	29%	53%	12%	6%	0%	0%
British Politics and Government since 1900	92	21%	61%	16%	0%	0%	0%
A12720P1	92	21%	61%	16%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	24	21%	71%	8%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	68	21%	57%	19%	0%	0%	0%
Comparative Demographic Systems	5						
A12741P1	5						
DPPE	5						
Comparative Government	66	35%	61%	5%	0%	0%	0%
A12719P1	66	35%	61%	5%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	8	13%	88%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	58	38%	57%	5%	0%	0%	0%
Comparative Political Economy	21	19%	67%	10%	5%	0%	0%

A17325P1	21	19%	67%	10%	5%	0%	0%
DMHP	1						
DPPE	20	20%	65%	10%	5%	0%	0%
Government and Politics of the United States	26	31%	69%	0%	0%	0%	0%
A12722P1	26	31%	69%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	6	17%	83%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	20	35%	65%	0%	0%	0%	0%
International Relations	151	26%	62%	9%	1%	0%	1%
A12731P1	151	26%	62%	9%	1%	0%	1%
DMHP	25	20%	60%	8%	4%	0%	8%
DPPE	126	28%	63%	10%	0%	0%	0%
International Relations in the Era of the Cold War	22	23%	73%	5%	0%	0%	0%
A12730P1	22	23%	73%	5%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	6	17%	83%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	16	25%	69%	6%	0%	0%	0%
International Relations in the Era of Two World Wars	6	50%	50%	0%	0%	0%	0%
A12729P1	6	50%	50%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	4						
DPPE	2						

Marx and Marxism	17	35%	65%	0%	0%	0%	0%
A12734P1	17	35%	65%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	2						
DPPE	15	40%	60%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Modern British Government and Politics	36	22%	72%	3%	0%	0%	0%
A12721P1	36	22%	72%	3%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	5						
DPPE	31	23%	71%	3%	0%	0%	0%
Political Sociology	83	25%	59%	11%	2%	2%	0%
A12737P1	82	26%	60%	11%	2%	1%	0%
DMHP	12	25%	75%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DPPE	70	26%	57%	13%	3%	1%	0%
A12737S1	1						
DPPE	1						
Political Thought: Bentham to Weber	10	40%	60%	0%	0%	0%	0%
A12733P1	10	40%	60%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	3						
DPPE	7	43%	57%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau	14	21%	71%	0%	7%	0%	0%

A12732P1	14	21%	71%	0%	7%	0%	0%
DMHP	4						
DPPE	10	20%	80%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Politics in China	23	17%	48%	26%	9%	0%	0%
A12743P1	23	17%	48%	26%	9%	0%	0%
DPPE	23	17%	48%	26%	9%	0%	0%
Politics in Europe	6	33%	50%	0%	0%	0%	17%
A12723P1	6	33%	50%	0%	0%	0%	17%
DPPE	6	33%	50%	0%	0%	0%	17%
Politics in Latin America	12	42%	58%	0%	0%	0%	0%
A12726P1	12	42%	58%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	2						
DPPE	10	50%	50%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Union	17	18%	82%	0%	0%	0%	0%
A12724P1	17	18%	82%	0%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	4						
DPPE	13	15%	85%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Politics in South Asia	9	67%	33%	0%	0%	0%	0%
A12727P1	9	67%	33%	0%	0%	0%	0%

DPPE	9	67%	33%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Politics in Sub-Saharan Africa	18	28%	56%	6%	6%	0%	6%
A12725P1	18	28%	56%	6%	6%	0%	6%
DMHP	4						
DPPE	14	29%	57%	7%	7%	0%	0%
Politics in the Middle East	30	33%	63%	0%	0%	0%	3%
A12728P1	30	33%	63%	0%	0%	0%	3%
DMHP	7	43%	43%	0%	0%	0%	14%
DPPE	23	30%	70%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Social Policy	29	24%	72%	3%	0%	0%	0%
A12740P1	29	24%	72%	3%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	3						
DPPE	26	23%	73%	4%	0%	0%	0%
Sociological Theory	6	50%	33%	17%	0%	0%	0%
A12735P1	6	50%	33%	17%	0%	0%	0%
DMHP	2						
DPPE	4						
Special Subject in Politics: Feminist Theory	28	36%	54%	7%	0%	0%	4%
A17606P1	28	36%	54%	7%	0%	0%	4%

DMHP	5						
DPPE	23	35%	57%	9%	0%	0%	0%
Special Subject in Politics: International Security and Conflict	48	38%	56%	4%	2%	0%	0%
A15594P1	48	38%	56%	4%	2%	0%	0%
DMHP	4						
DPPE	44	36%	59%	2%	2%	0%	0%
The Politics of the European Union	5						
A12744P1	5						
DMHP	2						
DPPE	3						
Theory of Politics	124	23%	61%	10%	2%	0%	1%
A15005P1	124	23%	61%	10%	2%	0%	1%
DMHP	18	6%	61%	22%	0%	0%	6%
DPPE	106	26%	61%	8%	3%	0%	0%
Thesis in Politics	16	25%	63%	6%	0%	0%	6%
A12746S1	16	25%	63%	6%	0%	0%	6%
DMHP	5						
DPPE	11	27%	64%	9%	0%	0%	0%
Grand Total	940	28%	61%	8%	1%	0%	1%

Report of the Politics Subject Board 2024-25

Membership: The Politics Subject Board consisted of the internal Politics examiners on the PPE and History and Politics Boards, and the Politics external examiner. It was supported by the Undergraduate Manager, the Undergraduate Studies Coordinator and the Education Manager from DPIR, as well as by the administrators of the PPE and History and Politics Boards. The Board was also grateful for statistical help provided by Maria Puolakkainen.

CoIP and PSED: At all its meetings, the Board noted the Conflict of Interest Policy and the Public Sector Equality Duty.

Conventions: The PSB Conventions were considered by the Board at its first meeting and released to students via Canvas and email reminder after receiving the approval of the Social Sciences Division. No significant changes were made to the Conventions this year. No new examining methods and procedures were introduced for the first time this year.

Examination setting: The PSB reviewed, discussed and advised on all draft undergraduate examination papers in Politics at its second meeting, providing feedback and comments to paper-setters, before approving of final drafts of all the papers. It also offered support and advice to those paper-setters who were new to the business of setting examination papers. The external examiner was also involved in reviewing and advising on all the examination papers.

MARKING

The PSB offered advice and guidance to all those marking Politics papers, especially those doing so for the first time. At its third meeting, the PSB considered the following:

Marks outside the range of initial marks: There were no cases of marks outside the range of initial marks this year.

Alleged plagiarism: Markers raised possible concerns about one script which were investigated and found to be unwarranted. No cases of alleged plagiarism were flagged by examiners, nor were identified via Turnitin reports.

Alleged poor academic practice: No cases of poor academic practice arose this year.

Exceptionally low-scoring theses: There were no exceptionally low-scoring theses this year.

Exceptionally low-scoring scripts: There were 5 scripts with marks of below 30. In 4 cases, these were scripts with missing answers, or very short (single paragraph, or single word) answers. In one case, 3 answers were given, but of exceptionally poor quality.

Analysis of marks: Cases of large differences between initial markers were reported as follows:

1. Difference >=15 marks: 18 scripts (of which 5 were referred to a third marker)
- Difference of 10-14 marks: 68 scripts (of which 2 were referred to a third marker)

The statistics for each paper and marker were reviewed by the PSB at its third meeting.

In the cases of two papers in International Relations, the Board noted that one pair of submitted initial marks was significantly discrepant. It invited each marker pair X and Y to comment and their comments were shared with the PSB. The comments did not suggest final agreement between X and Y on the quality of the scripts, and also that there had been difficulties in reconciliation beyond the cases in which there was no agreed mark. In these two cases, the Board asked a third marker to examine not just the usual cases in which X and Y could not agree, but also the cases with the largest gaps between the initial marks. These third marks and script reviews suggested that there was a case for rescaling to a mark closer to Y's initial mark. These findings were discussed by the Board and the full set of other scripts were made available to the external and the IR examiner on the PSB, with (i) an algorithm suggested by the Board in the light of the statistics, the markers' comments, the third marks and the script reviews, (ii) the flagging of the scripts of candidates who might be disadvantaged if this algorithm were applied. The external and the IR examiner's recommendation of the appropriate rescaling algorithm was adopted, namely that, where a third marker's mark or reviewer's mark existed, this would be the final mark. Otherwise, the final mark would be Y's mark -1.

All the Board's findings and recommendations were forwarded to the PPE and History and Politics boards. These boards were responsible for classification, and also for consideration of mitigating circumstances: comments on these matters will be found in their reports.

The Board has no recommendations to make regarding future or further changes in examining methods, procedures and examination conventions.

The PSB is very grateful indeed to Sarah Dunkley-Smith, Violet Brand, Chloe Funnell, Jenny Crewe and Maria Puolakkainen for their efficiency, advice and supportiveness, which continue to set the highest standards of professionalism.

Nick Owen

Chair, Politics Subject Board

September 2025.

Report on A15005P1 and A12704P1Theory of Politics

124 candidates took this paper.

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	**27**
2	**9**
3	**39**
4	**36**
5	**41**
6	**52**
7	**57**
8	**33**
9	**21**
10	**26**
11	**25**
12	**6**

Summary reflections on the paper as a whole
The quality of scripts ranged rather widely this year. As always, the best scripts showed excellent knowledge of the literature, and drew on that knowledge to present a focused answer to the specific essay question. More average scripts rather sacrificed depth for breadth, while weaker scripts often presented a mass of points found in the literature without any clear sense of how they addressed the question or what line of argument the candidate was pressing.

Brief remarks on individual questions

Question 1. What is a better remedy to injustice: redistribution or recognition? (27 answers)

Some thoughtful reflections on the strengths and weaknesses of both redistribution and recognition. Many candidates argued that both were required, but the best essays recognised potential tensions between the two (e.g. drawing on Fraser), and either sought to defuse those tensions or argued for one remedy over the other. Some candidates were evidently unaware of the meaning of 'recognition' in this context, and took it to be about recognising the fact there was an injustice, which tended to lead to rather poor answers. Some sought to turn the question into one about distributive vs. relational egalitarianism. This could be a successful strategy if the essay carefully explained how relational egalitarianism related to recognition and maintained the focus on remedying injustice – but candidates often failed to do this, and as a result failed to directly address the question.

Question 2. Does an appeal to rights serve any purpose that cannot be served by appeal to interests, values, and principles? (9 answers)

A tricky question, and the second least popular, but one that was well-answered by several of those who took it on. Strong essays showed good understanding of the literature on both the nature and function of rights, and offered sophisticated analyses of the distinctive role that

rights might play. Weaker essays tended to fall into conceptual confusion or to get somewhat lost in seeking to distinguish the place of rights from the other concepts mentioned in the question.

Question 3. What, if anything, can colonial violence tell us about the nature of power more generally? (39 answers)

The fourth most popular question. Candidates generally showed good knowledge of the relevant literature, drawing especially on Fanon, Arendt, and Foucault. Weaker essays struggled to move beyond an exposition of the views of such thinkers, or to move beyond a discussion of colonial violence to address the question of the more general lessons about power that can be drawn. Stronger essays were more successful in both of these respects.

Question 4. 'Arguments appealing to the benefits or justice of a state can show the advantages of the rule of law but can never justify obligations to obey the law.' Discuss. (36 answers)

Another popular question. Many candidates drew on Simmons' distinction between justification and legitimacy, which was a helpful way to frame the question. Weaker essays struggled to move beyond this conceptual distinction thus to explain *why* benefits and/or justice might only produce the former and not the latter. Some candidates stuck too closely to material from the lecture, and simply recounted the debate about fair play and/or natural duty theory. Better essays moved beyond this to offer interesting arguments as to why benefits/justice could or could not justify political obligation.

Question 5. 'Various inequalities are objectionable, but not because equality itself is valuable.' Discuss. (41 answers)

The third most popular question, but a difficult one. Candidates often showed good knowledge of relevant material, such as the distinction between telic and deontic egalitarianism and the levelling down objection. But identifying clear reasons why we should think that equality is or is not itself valuable proved challenging. Many candidates drew on the distinction between distributive and relational egalitarianism, to consider whether one or the other was valuable in itself, although at times this led to simply rehearsing the debate between those forms of egalitarianism without addressing the specific question. Beyond that distinction, surprisingly little tended to be said about different kinds of inequalities and why they might be objectionable. But stronger essays offered sophisticated discussions of such issues.

Question 6. 'The master's tools will never dismantle the master's house' (LORDE). Is this a fair criticism of liberal feminism? (52 answers)

The second most popular question. Candidates showed good knowledge of various criticisms of liberal feminism, and many offered thoughtful reflections on whether the use of liberal 'tools' was doomed to fail as a way to achieve feminist ends. However, there was a tendency to be somewhat uncharitable toward the view, and some essays showed very little knowledge of actual liberal feminist thought. The best essays considered what might be said in defence of liberal feminism, even if they nonetheless took the criticism to be sound.

Question 7. Does the extent to which one's desires are shaped by prevailing norms and social expectations have any bearing on whether one's actions are free? (57 answers)

The most popular question. Candidates drew on a pleasingly wide range of material and often made sophisticated arguments concerning whether there were any connections between the sources of one's desires and one's freedom. Some candidates couldn't resist the temptation to simply explain what theorists of negative and positive liberty would say about the question. Better essays that used that framework used the question as a way to argue for the superiority of a particular approach to freedom.

Question 8. If democracy aims to be a political system which enables citizens to relate as equals, what does this imply for the form and methods of democratic politics? (33 answers)

For this question candidates often distinguished between aggregative and deliberative democracy, usually to argue that the latter best enables citizens to relate as equals. Better essays went further by addressing objections to deliberative democracy in this respect, and by offering more concrete discussion of the forms and methods of democratic politics that are required in order to better realise that ideal. In this vein, some candidates showed good knowledge of recent literature on 'open democracy', mini-publics, etc.

Question 9. 'Nonviolent direct action seeks to create such a crisis and establish such creative tension that a community that has consistently refused to negotiate is forced to confront the issue' (KING). What are the implications of this claim for when and how political resistance should be conducted? (21 answers)

The answers to this question reflected a pleasingly broad range of thinkers: King, Brownlee, Celikates, Rawls, Malcom X, Pineda, even Fanon. Candidates tended to focus their analyses of King's quotation on the normative justification for non-violent direct action rather than on the political-theoretical significance of "creative tension." Better essays extended and contextualised that normative justification question by combining accounts of obligation and moral responsibility with critical readings of 'white ignorance' and colonial violence. Strong answers also grappled with the complex character of the quotation and addressed several of its multiple aspects (non-violence, creative tension, context of consistent refusal to negotiate, etc.).

Question 10. ‘Principles of distributive justice apply globally but they apply to states and not to individuals.’ Discuss. (26 answers)

Candidates showed good familiarity with debates concerning what kinds of relations, if any, people needed to be in in order for principles of distributive justice to apply. The challenge in the question was to move beyond that discussion to identify what kind of view would endorse the idea of global principles but hold that they only apply at the level of the state, and to consider the plausibility of that kind of view. Some candidates met that challenge admirably, while others struggled.

Question 11. Is it a constraint on a theory of justice that it must be acceptable to all reasonable citizens? (25 answers)

Candidates took a range of approaches to this question. Some tackled it through the debate about the fact-dependence of normative principles, others through debates concerning feasibility, others by discussing the merits of the original position, and others using the literature on political liberalism, neutrality and perfectionism. The last of these provided the most direct route into the question, and led to some strong essays that showed good knowledge of debates regarding the political liberal ‘reasonable acceptability requirement’. The other strategies could also be successful, but required more work to clearly tie the argument to the specific question.

Question 12. Does conservatism contain any resources by which to distinguish between desirable and undesirable social changes? (6 answers)

The least popular question, but generally well-answered by those who wrote on it. Candidates showed good knowledge of central aspects of conservative thought, and made interesting arguments regarding the extent to which those ideas enabled conservatives to evaluate social changes.

Report on A12719P1 Comparative Government

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	37
2	38
3	24
4	3
5	5
6	1
7	14
8	7
9	13
10	16
11	33
12	7

Sixty-six candidates took the exam in Trinity term 2025. There was a significant range of questions answered. Final marks ranged from 54 to 76, with an overall average of 67. Twenty-three candidates (35%) achieved a first-class mark. These candidates not only showed a broad knowledge of the main theories and findings from the relevant literature but also reflected on the strengths and limitations of the evidence base they were using to support their arguments.

Question One: What other strategies can dictators pursue, beyond co-optation and repression, to ensure their survival in power?

This was the second most popular question. Most students were able to refer correctly to legitimation strategies and distinguish between their various dimensions, while some also discussed issues related to media control and other informational tactics. Better answers discussed the relationship between the various strategies and contrasted their likely effectiveness across different types of dictatorship. Conversely, several answers failed to distinguish between authoritarian control and power sharing issues and the role of institutions in both. Weaker answers relied heavily on lecture material and focused on co-optation and repression rather than on alternative strategies of survival. Overall, arguments and findings related to indoctrination techniques (patriotic education, media control) could have been discussed more.

Question Two: What are the most convincing theoretical accounts regarding the role of international factors in democratization?

This is the question which received most answers: almost 19%. Candidates rightly focused on assessing the plausibility of wave arguments regarding diffusion and social norms, evaluated evidence regarding the role of linkage and leverage, or more direct interventions of international actors in the context of the Cold War and its ending (e.g. authoritarian backstop removal, the role of the Catholic Church or of EU conditionality). Better answers explicitly compared the mechanisms posited by these theories and contrasted their ability to explain

cases pertaining to different waves of democratization. Strong candidates also reflected on how these theories complement and interact with domestic-focused explanations of democratization.

Question Three: In what ways and under what conditions is the so-called 'commitment problem' a problem during clientelistic transactions?

The fourth most answered question, this generated some excellent answers. Candidates were generally able to explain the commitment problem, to disaggregate its components (brokers-voters and party-brokers) and to discuss salient conditions (e.g. vote secrecy, voter deprivation, strength of party machines, pervasiveness of norms of reciprocity). The better answers explained why the commitment problem is not an issue in clientelistic exchanges directed at turnout buying, turf protection and credibility signalling. Good candidates contrasted findings from different regions and from canonical texts with newer work and were able to competently criticize issue of survey design and other methodological or interpretation problems in some of these studies.

Question Four: 'The power of an interest group depends greatly on what 'interest' the group serves.' Discuss.

Only four candidates answered this question. All responses built on Olson's logic of collective action, and virtually all referred to information asymmetry as an alternative explanation for the degree of power exercised by interest groups. Better answers were able to critically discuss mechanisms linking interest group resources to political opportunity structures and policy networks (e.g. with respect to the ability of corporate interests and financial lobbies to change regulations directly affecting them or ensure favourable policy drift). The discussion of interest group content was mostly limited to size and ability to distribute selective goods and apply coercion, and few candidates discussed other types of variation (e.g. exogenous vs endogenous).

Question Five: Are constitutional court justices merely 'politicians in robes'?

Five candidates chose this question. Most answers related the prompt to research on models of judicial decision-making and discussed the circumstances under which judges can have their preferences enacted or are able to influence the normative structure of politics. While some interpreted strategic behaviour (i.e. moderating decisions in anticipation of legislative override or non-implementation) as a form of political behaviour, others argued the opposite. Better answers assessed the extent to which the argument is plausible by explicitly comparing higher law constitutions and legislative supremacy constitutions, and common law systems and civil law systems or by referring to variation in the way justices are selected.

Question Six: 'The optimal democratic constitution is short and easy to amend.' Do you agree?

Only one candidate chose this question. The response emphasized the distinct constitutional needs of established democracies as opposed to young, unconsolidated democracies or divided societies. The candidate focused on how more rigid constitutions can be a safeguard against executive aggrandizement and argued such a feature is not needed in consolidated democracy where politicians adhere to liberal democratic values, which is debatable. The answer also rightly discussed the connection between constitutional design and national identity building processes, drawing on relevant research and empirical examples.

Question Seven: How do party organization features influence the voter linkage strategies pursued by mainstream and challenger political parties?

Seven candidates answered this question. While most referred correctly to organisational resources and structures, very few went beyond mentioning differences in party membership and territorial branches to address the degree of centralisation, or aspects of intra-party democracy. With respect to the second part of the question, a majority of responses concentrated either on programmatic appeals regarding issue positions and issue avoidance, or on strategies of competence mobilisation. In turn, very few answers connected party organisation features to parties' ability to pursue non-programmatic linkage strategies (such as clientelism or charismatic appeals). Better answers explicitly linked the evolution of party organisational models to ideological positioning and distinct voter appeal strategies. Stronger candidates also reflected on how linkage strategies in turn influence party organisation (e.g. ideological convergence leading to decreasing party membership). Weaker responses compared differences in linkage strategies between mainstream and challenger parties without linking them clearly to differences in party organisation.

Question Eight: Are legislatures in presidential systems superior to parliaments in parliamentary systems when it comes to executive oversight?

The question was chosen by 11% of candidates. Most of them compared the different (career) incentives that the fusion vs. separation of powers create for legislators to engage in oversight. Some also drew on principal agent theory to discuss the differences in delegation problems and the screening tools available in the two types of constitutional systems. Better answers emphasized the heterogeneity of the two categories and linked variation in oversight with executive decree power, veto player distribution, party and electoral system features, or the presence of coalition governments. Only a few answers referred explicitly to the actions of opposition parties and legislators, and across all answers, institutional features creating monitoring and oversight opportunities for opposition or majority MPs could have been discussed more (e.g. in relation to budgetary oversight or inquiry committees). Weaker answers simply reproduced arguments regarding the risks of deadlock and democratic breakdown of presidential systems.

Question Nine: In what ways do electoral systems affect the outcomes of economic policymaking?

One in five candidates answered this question, and several candidates produced very strong essays. Most responses cited higher welfare spending, more redistribution and growth under PR while also discussing likely mechanisms (e.g. class coalitions, broad based policies because of coalition governments vs targeted, pork-barrel spending in majoritarian systems). Stronger candidates addressed issues of endogeneity (i.e. PR adopted in countries with more leftist-leaning voters, class coalitions or high level of economic coordination prior to adopting PR). Similarly, more sophisticated answers reflected on how the relationship is complicated by the clarity of accountability that the electoral system enables, and by the rise of radical right parties.

Question Ten: Why are democracies better at providing public goods than autocracies?

Mechanisms: democratic institutions directly encourage public goods provision because of representation (of lower and middle classes/ median voter preferences re redistribution and such goods), accountability (electoral incentive to gain votes – broad policies, electoral punishment incentives fewer rents more collective goods) and selection (of better leaders, not re-electing incompetent ones);

This was a relatively popular question, chosen by almost a quarter of candidates. Most answers focused on accountability mechanisms, while some also referred to better selection and information availability. The diversity of answers nicely illustrated that the question allowed several possible angles for comparison (e.g. contrasting democracies with developmental regimes, democracies and autocracies with various levels of state capacity, or within authoritarian systems, comparisons between electoral and non-competitive regimes). Weaker responses referred generically to the provision of public goods without discussing specific outcomes (e.g. regarding health or education) or variation within them (e.g. provision of more visible goods). Stronger candidates commented on the methodological strengths and weaknesses of the findings in this literature.

Question Eleven: Is it possible to make generalizations about the causes of state formation across different historical eras?

This was the third most popular question. Most responses chose to focus on the straightforward argument that the predatory state-making theory does not generalise well across time. Better answers considered sequencing and path dependencies and explicitly discussed the very different conditions faced by latecomers to state formation with respect to resources available to finance war, strategies of extraction, the nature of the international system, or the role of external actors. While most essays carefully defined what states are, and the starting period of their analyses, few explicitly discussed the conceptual difference between state formation and state building and why formation in different historical eras has direct implications for state building. Stronger essays also reflected on the role of geography

across historical eras, (i.e. influencing the incentives for controlling territory and building state infrastructure) or that of ethnic nationalism.

Question Twelve: Are the differences in the formation and composition of cabinets in presidential and parliamentary regimes the main explanation for the differences in the legislative success of the executives in those regimes?

This question was chosen by 11% of candidates. While most respondents were correctly able to connect the different incentives in establishing and maintaining a parliamentary majority in the two types of regimes, only a few discussed in more depth the key differences in cabinet formation and composition that the question referred to. The answers rarely evaluated differences in the appointment of partisan and non-partisan ministers, or in the proportionality in portfolio allocation and their implications for the success of governmental or presidential bills. These aspects were discussed in the lecture and covered by readings in the syllabus (e.g. Amorim Neto 2006 and Cheibub 2007). Some candidates were able to point to relevant alternative explanations for executives' legislative success such as varying levels of agenda control, or the different incentives for majority legislators to (not) support the bills initiated by the executive and linked these factors to parliamentary voting unity levels and roll rates.

Report on A12720P1 British Politics and Government since 1900

1. How much responsibility do Westminster politicians in the 1910s and early 1920s bear for EITHER violence in Ireland at that time OR the Troubles in Northern Ireland from 1968? The best answers to this question defined responsibility clearly: both what form of responsibility (political, moral, causal) and how it might be measured, and also responsibility for what. Violence was almost always understood as that between and among Irish nationalists and Irish unionists: surprisingly few answers considered British state violence. (10 answers).

2. Was it inevitable after 1918 that the Labour Party would become the Conservatives' main electoral opponent? 'Inevitable' was a powerful trigger-word in this question. Good answers unpacked what might be meant by it. Weaker answers mostly just provided a standard 'set of factors' to explain why the Labour Party emerged and grew, without making it clear which of these 'might have been otherwise', and which not. The best answers saw that the question really involved thinking about three parties, not one. (39 answers).

3. When did New Liberalism end as a programme of government? A very large range of end-dates were given to this question. Some candidates thought that New Liberalism had died before 1914, amid Liberal divisions over taxation, land reform, labour relations, rearmament, etc. Others thought that 'New Liberalism' was still visible in 'New Labour', or even beyond. Eliciting this range of answers was part of the point of asking the question, so the high marks went on the basis of the quality and accuracy of the evidence and reasoning offered for the choice made. (25 answers).

4. If most women suffragists were Liberals, why were the Conservatives the main electoral beneficiaries of women's suffrage? Two things for candidates to reasonably disagree with in the question itself: (i) whether most women suffragists were Liberals; and (ii) whether the Conservatives were the main electoral beneficiaries of women's suffrage. Candidates could also disagree with the implied paradox. Some argued effectively that some Liberal women suffragists voted Conservative when they got the vote (as did some Liberal men) without inconsistency because of what happened to the Liberals. Others pointed out that most women voters after 1918 had not been active suffragists, Liberal or otherwise, so were not caught by the paradox. (32 answers).

5. What kept British governments from solving the unemployment problem between the world wars? Not many answers, but even so a wide range of factors were cited in the answers to this question. The weaker answers tended to be technically weaker on what could have been done to 'solve the unemployment problem', or even on what the 'unemployment problem' actually was. Weaker answers also tended to be unsubtle, e.g. in

failing to appreciate what British governments did do to address unemployment, e.g. in stimulating trade, or in relief works; or in maintaining that Keynes' ideas were wholly unknown or unappealing to interwar Governments. (4 answers).

6. What ideological aims, if any, did the Conservative governments have between 1951 and 1964? This was a difficult question for those who wanted to write about whether the Conservative Governments 1951-64 departed from the postwar 'consensus', or why they won elections. There was no getting around the necessity to talk about ideology. Slightly better answers looked at these governments through a 'Thatcherite' lens, asking whether the ideological aims of the governments of the 1980s were already visible in 1951-64. Some candidates thought 'one nation' was an ideology, and some thought it was an attempt to avoid having (or exposing) an ideology. (14 answers).

7. Did Labour governments in the 1960s and 1970s sacrifice effective governance for party unity? Most answers to this question divided up their analysis: considering first whether and why the Labour governments were ineffective, and then whether and why they were divided. The better answers were just more nuanced in distinguishing between periods and policy areas of greater or lesser effectiveness, and between different types of disunity, of varying seriousness. The best answers probed the implied trade-off between 'effective governance' and 'party unity'. There is, after all, a possibility that they are not linked, or not linked in the way that the word 'sacrifice' implies. (15 answers).

8. Why was renegotiation and referendum used in 1975 and 2016 to tackle the Europe question? Unfortunately for some candidates, it was not sufficient to write only about 2016 to answer this question satisfactorily. The best answers set 1975 and 2016 in the frame of a longer consideration of engagement with 'Europe', which made it clear why resort was made to renegotiation and referendum only at these junctures. They also made it clear what was distinctive and attractive (and to whom) about the renegotiation and referendum strategy. (8 answers).

9. How much did Margaret Thatcher change the Conservative Party? A hugely popular question, but some candidates missed the word 'Party' and answered too broadly on how much Thatcher changed all sorts of other things. Here too a wider knowledge was needed: of what the Conservative Party was before Thatcher. Most answers focused tightly on party 'beliefs', or slightly more widely on 'policies'. Other aspects of 'party' could also have been considered and probably should have been: e.g. party organization, party identity, leadership, membership, candidate selection, voting support, electoral campaigning, etc. Good answers also considered whether the party 'stayed changed' after Thatcher, as a way of indicating the durability of the changes. (63 answers).

10. How did constitutional reform serve the interests of New Labour, 1997-2010? Lots of answers here too, but the focus on 'constitutional reform' threw some candidates who wanted to write about New Labour, but not about that aspect. Some candidates located constitutional reform close to the heart of the New Labour programme, e.g. via conceptions of active citizenship, or the politics of renewed nationhood and devolution in Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland. Others argued that constitutional reform served electoral interests by drawing across the tactical votes of Liberal Democrats. A few candidates thought that in the end it did not serve New Labour interests, but could be seen as a hangover from the years of opposition when the party's priority was making life difficult for government. (50 answers).

11. Do economic conditions in Britain determine the low success rate of extremist parties? This question required a lot of clear definitions to be made. There was, for example, a lot to unpack in 'economic conditions', which the better answers did more successfully: in defining which 'conditions' exactly, and explaining precisely the mechanism by which they might have inhibited extremist parties, where they did. Candidates also needed to decide if they agreed that extremist parties always had low success rates – throughout and everywhere? - and, if not 'economic conditions', what else explained the low success rate. (5 answers).

12. How should we best account for the changing salience of immigration in British politics since 1945? There was a large preliminary task to be done here: delineating the changing salience of immigration in British politics over a long period, which involved voters, campaigns and social movements in and beyond migrant communities, as well as political parties and governments, all with their own degrees of 'salience'. Explanations had to consider many factors: rates and forms of migration, economic, social and geographic prompts and responses, and electoral competition between and within parties. Faced with this task, the best answers were selective, in identifying key moments of high salience, or periods of high and low salience to explain the changes. (5 answers).

Report on A12721P1 Modern British Government and Politics

35 candidates sat this paper

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	25
2	8
3	11
4	18
5	9
6	6
7	12
8	3
9	4
10	2
11	0
12	7

Summary reflections on the paper as a whole

The overall quality of the scripts was high. The average mark across the exam was 66.8 with a standard deviation of 3.8. Out of 35 students, 8 achieved first class honours. There were no fails. Students usually preformed strongest when they focused on the specific question at hand, engaged with the academic literature, and utilised documents where it was pertinent to.

Brief remarks on individual questions

1. Would codification address ambiguities around where power lies in the British constitution? A popular question. Weaker answers were too broad in their analysis of the constitution; stronger ones focused on codification, and also on whether it would address ambiguities, rather than all the other things it might do, for better or worse. Stronger answers discussed related academic literature and offered in depth analysis of documents like the cabinet manual (what specifically was it trying to achieve).

2. ‘Executive dominance of the legislative process is incompatible with Parliamentary sovereignty.’ Do you agree? Stronger answers provided clear definitions of sovereignty: once this was done it was easier to argue whether executive dominance was in tension with it; or whether, on the contrary, 'dominance' was the means by which parliamentary sovereignty was achieved. Weaker answers also lacked focus on the 'legislative process' itself, rather than other aspects of the legislature. Some stronger answers discussed relevant documents and court cases from recent years.

3. What are the potential benefits and drawbacks of a more politically accountable UK civil service? 'Politically accountable' needed definition - accountable to who? for what? Stronger answers provided this; weaker ones were over-general reviews of the state of the civil service, or on the tension between ministers and civil servants. Some stronger answers discussed key aspects of civil service development and doctrine (Northcote–Trevelyan Report, Haldane principle, Osmotherly rule, etc.).

4. Has the power of British Prime Ministers increased or decreased in the 21st century?

Good answers managed to treat both the variations created by the capabilities of individual holders of the office, and the resources and formal powers. This still left some explanatory gaps, however, so really good answers also considered how they might be bridged. Surprisingly few answers considered the Prime Minister's close team, or relations with the parliamentary party. Some weak answers did not focus on the temporal aspect of the question well. Some stronger answers incorporated concepts from relevant literature on this topic (Presidentialism and its critics, core executive model, etc.).

5. Did the Leveson Inquiry leave gaps that need to be addressed in terms of media accountability? Many candidates knew the details of Leveson and post-Leveson developments. Weaker answers discussed it in only general terms. Again the 'accountability' word needed definition. The criteria for 'need' were also under-examined - whose need?

6. In what areas, if any, has the UK Supreme Court since 2005 encroached on powers that used to be left to politicians? Some very well-informed answers about what has happened: good answers considered what was meant (or implied) by the term 'encroached'. These usually made direct reference to judgements in recent years. Weaker answers sometimes lacked precise knowledge of what the SC has and hasn't done, or claimed to do.

7. In what ways has devolution to Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland diminished the power of the Westminster Parliament? Weaker answers tended to be general surveys of the successes and failures of devolution; stronger ones had a sharper focus on the power of Westminster, and also a precise knowledge of what Westminster Parliament could and could not still do, and how that had changed, both before 1997 and since. Some stronger answers discussed concepts like the West Lothian question or the Sewel Convention. They also discussed recent legal and political developments (Gender Recognition Act, English Votes for English Laws, etc.).

8. ‘The push towards greater devolution within England reveals a lack of interest in reforming existing local government structures.’ Do you agree? Some candidates did not quite understand the claim that was being made in this question: specifically the distinction between 'devolution' and 'local government reform' as different pathways. Better answers

knew something about what had been done to reform local government structures; weaker ones knew only about English devolution, and what had worked there or not.

9. Has the rise of social media rendered print media irrelevant in UK political campaigning? Weaker answers were short on tests of relevance in campaigning, or short of compelling evidence; and surprisingly few answers made distinctions between different parties and the degree or ways in which they each seek to employ social media in their campaigning. Stronger answers were able to incorporate some of the empirical work that has been done by academics in recent years on this topic.

10. How influential have party members been within political parties on Brexit and related issues? Not many answers to this question: weaker answers tended to lack a focus on party members, as distinct from leaders, MPs, backers, etc. Again, stronger answers were able to incorporate some of the empirical work that has been done by academics in recent years on this topic.

11. Did the UK's relationship with the EU become more stable between the decision to leave in 2016 and the official withdrawal in 2020? Too few answers to comment.

12. 'The proliferation of electoral systems and the use of referendums since 1997 have not addressed the UK's voter apathy problems.' Do you agree? Good answers considered critically the assumption in the question that voter apathy might be influenced by the choice of electoral system, or the use of a referendum. Weaker answers tended to assume that this influence was to-be-expected. Stronger answers also considered the difference between an apathy problem and a turnout problem, and what the evidence for each might be (discussion of party strategies, sociological changes, etc.). Weaker answers were also sometimes awry about the turnout figures, and almost all answers would have gained from more detail on regional variation, variation by the social characteristics of the voter, etc.

Report on A12722P1 Government and Politics in the United States

The majority of candidates scored within the upper second-class range. On the whole this was an unimpressive set of examination answers relative both to previous years' scripts which one assessor (DK) has marked many times and to the standard of this year's Comparative Government papers which one assessor (DK) also marked. The latter paper's high quality answers and analyses demonstrated excellent intellectual strength and knowledge amongst PPE FHS candidates, resulting in many First Class standard answers.

This was not the case with the Gov & Pols of the United States scripts.

Responses lacked the analytical sharpness and conceptual clarity expected at the highest level and there was little First quality. While some candidates constructed coherent arguments and referenced relevant academic debates and empirical material, too often these were presented descriptively rather than critically. The standard of exposition was disappointing, frequently characterized by poor grammar and uncertain syntax. Candidates relied upon outdated sources (eg the ever-popular question about the judiciary) form which it can be inferred the reading list provided for this course needs revision.

Given that these defects were not present in the Comparative Government scripts sat at the same time, it may be useful to see how the reading lists for these two courses compare and whether there is an opportunity to update recommended readings on the US Pols paper. It might also be useful for those listed on the tutorial register as offering this paper to meet and discuss teaching perhaps with the course convenor.

Below is a breakdown by question of candidates' performance. There was a disappointing bunching of responses around a number of questions.

Distribution of answers by questions:

Qu 1 = 11; Qu 2= 7; Qu 3 = 7; Qu 4 = 5; Qu 5 = 4; Qu 6 = 13; Qu 7 = 0; Qu 8 = 4; Qu 9 = 11; Qu 10 = 1; Qu 11 = 4; Qu 12 = 11.

1. What is the role of race in American exceptionalism?

Many candidates demonstrated familiarity with the basic themes (e.g., de Tocqueville, Lipset, cultural vs institutional explanations). However, few answers offered critical engagement. Stronger answers distinguished between different approaches to exceptionalism; weaker ones relied heavily on narrative or recycled textbook material. Variation in analytical ambition led to a wide mark range.

2. When do states have the capacity to resist the federal government?

Candidates who selected this question generally produced thoughtful answers that engaged well with institutions and, intergovernmental dynamics, and contemporary examples. This was one of the more reliable questions in terms of quality.

3. Who holds power within political parties in the USA?

Candidates typically demonstrated empirical awareness of trends in party discipline, polarisation, and legislative control. The strongest responses engaged critically with literature on partisanship in Congress and the presidency. However, many essays were descriptive and did not move beyond established narratives, often with insufficient attention to defining basic concepts. There were few excellent responses, but most were competent.

4. Are voters in the United States "intoxicated" by partisanship?

This question tended to invite either well-developed, literature-rich arguments or relatively loose, empirical surveys. The best answers critically assessed the institutional and ideological roots of polarisation. Others were anecdotal or treated partisanship too vaguely.

5. Is it still true that Congress is inherently localistic?

Stronger essays focused on institutional design, party leadership, and lawmaking dynamics.

6. 'The same conditions that promote [the President's] leadership in form preclude a guarantee of leadership in fact.' (NEUSTADT) Discuss.

This was the most frequently attempted question with high variation in the quality of responses. Strong answers unpacked Neustadt's paradox of presidential weakness and the power to persuade. Weaker answers described presidential power without engaging the paradox or updating the framework.

9. To what extent is the Supreme Court constrained by the need to interpret the text of the Constitution?

This was a popular question, but many responses lacked critical engagement with the underlying tensions in constitutional interpretation. While most candidates mentioned the counter-majoritarian difficulty and judicial review, few went beyond Segal and Spaeth and surface-level exposition to explore deeper theoretical debates. Contemporary decisions were frequently cited without substantive analysis; most answers made hardly any reference to decisions. Only a small number of candidates demonstrated genuine analytical ambition; many essays fell into descriptive patterns and showed limited originality.

11. What are the political barriers to substantive racial equality in the USA?

This question revealed significant spread in candidate confidence and preparation. Stronger answers integrated academic literature on structural racism, policy retrenchment, and the

carceral state. Others relied on anecdotal or journalistic material, often missing the conceptual demands of the question.

12. Does the changing ownership structure of media in the United States have political consequences?

While some candidates provided well-structured essays, others wrote descriptively or did not answer the question directly. The best responses were conceptually clear and empirically grounded; the weakest failed to distinguish between media effects and broader political trends.

Report on A12723P1 Politics in Europe

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	**3**
2	**3**
3	**1**
4	**2**
5	**2**
6	**3**
7	**0**
8	**2**
9	**2**
10	**0**
11	**0**
12	**0**

There were six scripts of which three were excellent, two were good, and one was weak. Out of the 12 questions, eight questions attracted at least one answer, and four questions received no attempts. On average, the quality of individual answers was high. The best answers to the most popular answers (1,2,6) combined a deep and comprehensive understanding of the main theories of party system formation and party behaviour with an excellent grasp of the empirical details of party politics across European states.

Report on A12724P1 Politics of Russia in the Former Soviet Union

17 candidates took the exam in Trinity Term 2025: 13 PPE students and 4 HPol students. The standard was average for an undergrad script. Final marks ranged from 60 to 74, with an overall average of 65. Three candidates achieved a First-Class mark.

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	9
2	11
3	8
4	5
5	2
6	3
7	2
8	1
9	7
10	0
11	3
12	0

Frequency of responses: low (up to 4); middle (5 to 8); high (more than 8).

1. '*Perestroika* is not responsible for the collapse of the Soviet Union.' Discuss.

(High) = 9

This was the second most popular question, with more than half of the candidates answering this question. The stronger scripts engaged with the competing debates about Gorbachev's perestroika, including the ideological underpinnings and shortcomings of the reforms in the late twentieth century. They also connected their answers to other major themes covered in the course, such as nationalist tensions, economic challenges, and elites. The weaker scripts had unclear arguments and were descriptive in their responses. The marks for this question widely ranged from 55-73.

2. Do citizens' protests have any effect on post-Soviet political outcomes?

(High) = 11

This question was the most frequently answered on the exam. The stronger scripts did a good job engaging with the literature on revolutions, protests, and mobilizations in the

former Soviet space. Many of them also discussed the colour revolutions, including why and how they occurred, as well as detailed their varied outcomes across the former Soviet space. Some of the essays brought in contemporary political examples like the recent protests in Georgia. The weaker exams were descriptive and failed to engage with the literature on the reading list. The marks for this question ranged greatly from 58-78.

3. 'Post-Soviet autocracies are sustained by political parties, rather than individual rulers.' Do you agree?

(High) = 8

This question was the third most popular one answered on the exam. This question produced both very strong and weak answers. The strongest comparatively analysed political parties across the post-Soviet space and included specific cases and examples of where political parties have sustained and continue to sustain autocracies. They also engaged with the large body of literature on the role of individual leaders and elites in the former Soviet space. Several of the weaker scripts were descriptive and lacked a coherent argument. The marks for this question ranged from 58-73.

4. Were nationalist mobilisations across the Soviet Union inevitable in the late 1980s?

(Middle) = 5

Several candidates answered this question. When doing so, most examined the different drivers of nationalist mobilisation at the end of the Soviet Union and compared nationalist mobilisations in different republics to highlight the inevitability of nationalism becoming a source of conflict, especially between the Baltics and Central Asia. Some of the stronger essays also examined the existing theories around civic and ethnic understandings of nationalism, and the roles they played in politics within the former Soviet states. It is noteworthy that several candidates engaged with this literature in their essays when answering this question as only one student answered Question 8 on civic-ethnic nationalism (see below). The assigned marks for this question were around average and fell between 62-68.

5. Are there more differences than similarities among post-Soviet autocracies?

(Low) = 2

Very few students answered this question. The candidates did a decent job engaging with the literature on authoritarianism, formal institutions, constitutionalism, and presidentialism. In doing so, they largely showed that there are many similarities between post-Soviet regimes, despite the differences in their institutional design and strength of authoritarianism. The candidates also did a good job drawing on different examples from across the former Soviet space, especially in Central Asia and Russia.

6. To what extent is corruption in former Soviet societies a legacy of communism?

(Low) = 3

This answers for this question were overall good. The students who answered this question did a nice job engaging with the extensive literature and constructed coherent arguments to illustrate the connection between legacies of communism and corruption. The stronger candidates effectively demonstrated how corruption in the post-Soviet space was a strategy adopted for development at the end of communism as the post-Soviet states were being built. The stronger essays also included much of the relevant literature on corruption and communist legacies, as well as referenced several empirical examples, especially Russia.

7. What explains the persistence of hybrid regimes in post-Soviet states?

(Low) = 2

Very few students answered this question. Overall, both candidates did a good job laying out a clear argument and outlining the role of international and domestic factors as explanations for the persistence of hybrid regimes in post-Soviet states. The students also engaged well with the literature on hybrid regimes and incorporated empirical examples from across the former Soviet space to illustrate their arguments.

8. What understanding of nationalism is more useful for explaining politics in post-Soviet states: civic or ethnic?

(Low) = 1

Only one candidate answered this question. The low number of responses is notable as this topic has historically been a very popular one amongst students taking the course. Moreover, several candidates answered Question 4 on nationalist mobilisation, where there could have been overlap in the literature used to answer this question.

9. Assess the usefulness of the ‘resource curse’ for explaining contemporary politics in the Caspian basin.

(Middle) = 7

Several candidates answered this question. The answers to this question varied considerably and included both very strong and weak answers. The stronger essays defined the ‘resource curse’ as a concept and outlined the ongoing debates around it in political science scholarship. The stronger essays also illustrated how it continues to inform domestic politics in the former Soviet states by including a variety of examples across Central Asia and in the Caspian basin. The weaker essays failed to effectively answer the question, as they were quite descriptive and analytically weak. This could be partially due to the question style, which encouraged them to set out their own argument in order to ‘assess’ the resource

curse rather than expand on an argument implicit in the question. The assigned grades for this question ranged widely from 58-73.

10. Do formal institutions or societal cleavages matter more for political outcomes in former Soviet states?

(Low) = 0

No candidates answered this question.

11. 'We cannot understand political parties in the post-Soviet countries without also considering the integrity of elections.' Discuss.

(Low) = 3

Few candidates answered this question. All three essays were of average quality and engaged with the extensive literature about both the role of elections and political parties in the former Soviet space. The answers had coherent arguments and effectively answered the question.

12. How useful is the concept of 'post-Soviet' for describing the countries of the region today?

(Low) = 0

No candidates answered this question.

General Comments:

This exam's answers were similar to previous years. The strongest candidates impressively demonstrated their analytical capacity and drew extensively on the reading list. Weaker candidates engaged much less with the assigned readings and less convincingly connected their arguments to empirical examples.

Greater engagement with the lecture material would have helped several students' grades. As attendance at lectures dropped significantly throughout the term, future students taking this class might be reminded about the importance of the lectures for complementing their tutorials. Many students were also quite descriptive in their answers and/or wrote their essays by simply listing facts or chronologically outlining events. Attending lectures, engaging more with the reading list, and adding empirical examples would greatly improve many essays. Also notable is that the questions on the first half of the exam were more popular than the second half, with the first three questions being the most popular. The questions were randomised, so this does not suggest that the students only prepared the topics in the first half of the course.

Overall, the students this year were overall excellent. No one failed the exam and three achieved a First-Class grade. Many of the candidates showcased their breadth of knowledge

about the topics covered in the course, while also including their own arguments and empirical examples. This thus illustrates that they had read widely, engaged actively in their tutorials, and prepared effectively for the exam.

Report on A12725P1 Politics in Sub-Saharan Africa

18 students took this paper.

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	4
2	4
3	7
4	6
5	2
6	6
7	0
8	7
9	4
10	3
11	4
12	6

This examination was sat by eighteen candidates. Together they answered all but one question (Q7 on religion). The remaining questions all had several responses with Q3 on military coups and Q8 on gender the most popular (7 answers) and Q5 on political parties the least popular (2 answers).

Most candidates did rather well, with ten upper second class and five first-class results. There were three candidates that received substantially lower marks. In all three cases this was due to one or two essays either missing entirely or with very short, limited responses not presented in essay format. It appears the three candidates may not have managed the allotted examination time (3 hours) appropriately or they encountered a mental setback in the examination, involving a negative emotional or cognitive reaction. Of these three candidates, one received a failing mark, having answered only one essay question. In all three cases, the essays provided in full were of decent quality, suggesting these students' potential and hinting at time management issues or some form of mental setback, as suggested above. Among the remaining students, the distribution of marks across their three essays were relatively similar. For several students with greater divergence, it was the last essay that was significantly weaker, again suggesting an issue with timing.

The best scripts stood out for laying out arguments with precision and depth, putting various scholars into conversation, and showing a good understanding of key case studies. Weak answers often stated arguments without fully explicating them, provided rather convoluted or confused answers, or showed limited engagement with the literature and/or case studies.

Brief remarks on individual questions

Question 1: 'Anti-colonial nationalism has been both a tool for liberation and domination.' Discuss.

Answers: 4

The quality of answers for this question varied rather widely. Weaker answers struggled to keep focused on answering the essay question but ultimately agreed with the essay prompt and suggested broadly speaking that anti-colonial nationalism was once a tool for liberation (prior to independence) and has since been turned into a tool for domination. Higher marks were achieved by students who went beyond this somewhat simplistic dichotomy and explored the complex and contradictory ways in which anti-colonial nationalism has been employed by different actors both prior and after independence.

Question 2: Does the concept of neopatrimonialism obscure more about African politics than it reveals?

Answers: 4

Students answered this question rather well. Within that scope, weaker answers were somewhat imprecise in defining neopatrimonialism and in providing a nuanced discussion of the various critiques that have been levelled against the concept – with various critiques discussed as one and with limited evidence of a deeper understanding. Better answers provided a more careful initial discussion of the term and its potential application before providing several distinct critiques.

Question 3: “The resurgence of successful military coups since 2020 is primarily a product of changing international norms.” Discuss.

Answers: 7

This was one of the most popular questions and most students answered it relatively well, with some excellent essays. The best answers explored at some depth a few interrelated arguments supporting the salience of changing international norms alongside alternative explanations, specifically regarding domestic coup drivers. They engaged with the role of specific international actors (their changing attitudes and their declining or rising power) as well as concrete case studies of recent coups.

Question 4: Why has democratic consolidation varied markedly in Africa?

Answers: 6

Most essays on this question were somewhat bunched at the lower end of an upper second-class result. Students often struggled to provide a clear answer to the question, discussing reasons for limited democratic consolidation across Africa as opposed to variation. Better answers provided an explicit argument about variation and used comparative case studies to explore different trajectories with reference to specific factors that may help explain them.

Question 5: What explains the persistence of dominant parties in many African countries?

Answers: 2

The two students who answered this question received mid-range marks. They explored key factors, including the power of liberation credentials and incumbency advantage, and rooted answers in specific case studies (though some were more appropriate than others).

Question 6: Is ethnicity a salient factor in African politics?

Answers: 6

This was a popular question. The strongest answers rooted the political salience of ethnicity historically, with specific attention to the role of the colonial encounter, while also addressing variation in the degree and form of political salience across the continent today (addressing, for instance, the role of differing political structures and administrative boundaries). Several students also drew useful distinctions between primordial, instrumentalist and social-constructivist concepts of ethnicities, though weaker answers showed a limited understanding of these perspectives which then led to somewhat confused or imprecise arguments.

Question 7: To what degree does Islam influence public support for democracy?

Answers: 0

This question was not answered, which corresponds to its absence from lectures and classes. This is a topic that should be reconsidered during upcoming revisions of the course structure with an eye on capacity to teach on this topic.

Question 8: To what extent have African women succeeded in gaining substantive political power in recent decades?

Answers: 7

This was one of the most popular essay questions and produced some excellent answers. Most students did well in distinguishing between descriptive and substantive power and made some useful arguments as to why gains in the former have not always led to gains in the latter. The best answers provided a balanced account, discussing a number of distinct if related factors that have limited women's success in translating increasing descriptive representation into substantive power, whilst also discussing cases of relative success. Weaker answers engaged with the literature at a somewhat superficial level, at times missing or misrepresenting key arguments and case studies.

Question 9: Who is to blame for the failures of Structural Adjustment Programmes?

Answers: 4

This essay question produced mostly good to very good essays. The best answers showed a good understanding of what SAPs entailed, providing precise definitions with reference to specific policy packages, underlying economic assumptions, and prioritised goals. They then weighed the relative responsibility of international financial institutions in imposing flawed policies and African governments in failing to fully implement them. Somewhat weaker answers provided more imprecise discussions of what SAPs were or settled on one responsible actor without fully considering alternative explanations.

Question 10: "Africa's New Authoritarians provide a promising alternative model of development." Discuss.

Answers: 3

The quality of answers to this question varied markedly and included the overall highest individual mark. The best essay provided a well-rounded analysis that engaged scholarly arguments in favour and against the essay prompt whilst providing the student's own critical assessment. It considered the apparent success of new authoritarians in promoting economic growth by means of state-led development, whilst raising concerns regarding rising inequality, internal political instability, and rising debt. The weakest essay showed some understanding of the reasons why New Authoritarians have gained support as an alternative model of development but did not engage in any depth with scholarly critiques.

Question 11: "Epidemics in Africa have taught us that global health is much more about ensuring 'First World' security than it is about elevating 'Third World' suffering." Discuss.

Answers: 4

Weaker answers to this question struggled to explain the potential link between global health interventions and 'first world' security and, perhaps partly as a result, to keep answers closely focused on the essay question. Better answers used key scholars to explore the securitisation of global health responses and discourses which frame epidemics in Africa as a risk not only due to potential disease spread but also 'state failure'.

Question 12: What is the relationship between civil war onset and state capacity in Africa?

Answers: 6

The quality of answers to this question varied markedly. This essay question demanded an engagement with the literature on weak, fragile or failed states, which some students touched upon only briefly or not at all. On the whole, lack of serious engagement with state failure debates undermined the general quality of answers for this question. The omission is odd, given that state capacity is an important theme covered in lectures and tutorials. The best answers provided a critical engagement with literature on civil war causes but as alluded to above, the link to literature about weak, fragile or failed states was not well established, making for less than effective answers.

Report on A12726P1 Politics of Latin America

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	**6**
2	**2**
3	**3**
4	**3**
5	**5**
6	**2**
7	**2**
8	**6**
9	**6**
10	**1**
11	**0**
12	**0**

The examination, requiring students to answer three equally weighted questions out of twelve, saw a balanced distribution among the popular topics, indicating competence across the core curriculum areas of state formation, political economy, and democratization. The most frequently chosen questions addressed state capacity (Q1, 6 answers), economic liberalization (Q5, 5 answers), the rise of populism (q8, 6 answers), and democratic transition paths (q9, 6 answers), highlighting student engagement with agent-structure explanations for regional variation. Responses generally demonstrated strong use of comparative case studies, frequently drawing on examples such as Argentina, Chile, Brazil, and Venezuela to support arguments about diverging policy outcomes or institutional development. Results were very good, with all scripts ranking in upper second or first level. A key thematic strength across the scripts was the tendency to move beyond binary theoretical choices (e.g., arguing that trade/war are secondary to elite agency and geography in explaining state capacity, Q1) or debating the relative timing and mechanism of influence (e.g., determining that external pressures were merely the trigger for economic liberalization, which was ultimately driven by domestic policy choices, Q5). The questions that received fewer attempts (Q10, Q11 and Q12) all dealt with topics related with more specific dimensions of electoral behaviour, beyond general voting patterns in Q3.

Question 1: Is trade a better explanation than war for variation in state capacity across Latin America? (6 answers)

Most responses argued that trade is a better explanation than war primarily because the classical model linking interstate war to state capacity development fails in Latin America due to the historical lack of sustained interstate conflict. Sophisticated arguments concluded that both factors were ultimately secondary to structural features like political geography (size, terrain, and urban primacy) and the political actions of elites who decided whether or not to incorporate peripheral territories.

Question 2: 'The left turn was a temporary phenomenon powered by the early 2000s commodity boom.' Discuss. (2 answers)

Both answers largely disagreed with the proposition, arguing that the left turn was not merely temporary and was not solely powered by the commodity boom. The commodity boom was

acknowledged as an intervening factor that allowed leftist presidents (especially in commodity-reliant nations like Venezuela) to finance large redistribution programs, solidifying the movement once they were already in office.

Question 3: How important is ideology in explaining voting patterns in Latin America? (4 answers)

Students found ideology to be of limited importance in explaining voting patterns across the region, particularly due to the prevalence of ideological convergence and weak party brands. Best attempts focused on the dilution of party brands leading to voters being unable to reliably map parties onto a spatial model and turning to retrospective voting. They also highlighted the the greater importance of ideology in states with well-institutionalized, stable party systems (such as Uruguay and Chile), where parties maintain clear ideological platforms.

Question 4: To what extent do international economic factors constrain the policy choices of Latin American presidents? (3 answers)

Answers correctly proposed that international economic factors constrain policy choices to a large extent. The primary constraints stem from the volatility of commodity prices and vulnerability to currency crises. BBest answers highlighted how this pressure often forces "bait-and-switch" policy reversals towards neoliberal market policies to stabilize the currency or attract foreign investment, and how high commodity prices can temporarily grant programmatic freedom, and remittances can act as counter-cyclical insurance.

Question 5: Was economic liberalisation across Latin America the result of external pressures or domestic policy choices? (5 answers)

The consensus was that economic liberalization was primarily the result of domestic policy choices, even though external pressures provided the critical trigger. External pressures, such as the 1980s debt crisis and the IMF's Structural Adjustment Programs (SAPs), created the necessity for reform but pressures were mediated by domestic factors, like coalition building efforts, and the powerful internal electoral pressures.

Question 6: EITHER: To what extent is presidentialism responsible for policy gridlock in Latin America? OR: ‘Inequality, rather than poverty, is the main challenge for social policy in Latin America.’ Discuss. (2 answers)

- Presidentialism and Gridlock (1 answer): The response argued that presidentialism is not wholly to blame for policy gridlock. Gridlock is often a product of external factors, such as the existence of recalcitrant legislatures resulting from intense ideological divides or a high number of effective parties (e.g., Brazil).
- Inequality vs. Poverty (1 answer): The response argued that inequality is the main challenge for social policy. This is because Latin America faces deep structural issues that prevent meaningful redistribution, such as the truncated welfare system designed primarily for formally employed labor, and the problem of coalition hollowing, where cross-class support for redistribution wanes once easy funding, such as commodity windfalls, ends.

Question 7: Is the absence of deep social cleavages the main cause of volatility in Latin American party systems? (2 answers)

Both answers refuted the premise, arguing that while Latin America generally lacks deep-rooted social cleavages comparable to Europe (e.g., class, ethnicity), this absence is not the main cause of party system volatility. Instead, volatility is attributed primarily to historical and institutional factors. They correctly identified key factors such as the nature and number of authoritarian interruptions, permissive electoral and fiscal rules that promote the proliferation of small parties, and exogenous shocks (like economic crises) that lead to party brand dilution and the personalization of politics.

Question 8: Which factors explain the rise of populism in Latin America? (5 answers)

Essays generally convincingly proposed that the rise of populism is explained by a combination of institutional weakness, economic distress, and political strategy, often creating a self-reinforcing cycle. Populism thrives as a reaction to the failure of party politics, specifically the "dealignment". THey also highlighted that populist leaders use personalistic leadership and anti-establishment, anti-elite framing to attract large, disconnected voter segments.

Question 9: What explains variations in transition paths during the third wave of democratisation in Latin America? (6 answers)

Answers here satisfactorily engage the canonical literature, explaining variations in transition paths by the varying leverage and strategic interaction of key elite actors (incumbents, military) and the democratic forces.

The most sophisticated answers also challenged those explanations by including the role of labour as a generally understudied aspect, in line with Collier's typology.

Question 10: What factors explain the variation in degrees of clientelism across Latin American countries? (1 answer)

The answer proposes that variation in clientelism is largely explained by the political system's structure, specifically whether the state is centrally governed or decentralized. The general argument is correct, but there are some inconsistencies in the understanding of the importance of degrees of centralisation.

Report on A12727P1 Politics in South Asia

No. of students taking paper	9

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	**2**
2	**1**
3	**0**
4	**1**
5	**1**
6	**6**
7	**5**
8	**3**
9	**0**
10	**0**
11	**4**
12	**2**

Nine candidates answered the paper. As noted above and in the separate report, the overall quality and distribution of marks are discussed elsewhere.Across scripts, several recurring weaknesses were evident. Key terms were often invoked but not carefully defined or operationalised, which made subsequent claims difficult to test. Evidence was cited unevenly, with limited engagement with recent empirical literature and primary datasets, and some essays lacked a clearly signposted thesis and roadmap linking claims to evidence and inference. A few additional issues merit attention. Time management led some candidates to devote excessive space to background at the expense of analysis. In light of the above, the following actions are recommended. Before the examination, provide a short briefing on how to operationalise concepts and build indicator frameworks, including two worked mini-examples. Offer model outlines, one for an identity/foreign-policy essay and one for a reform/economy essay, to illustrate effective structure.

This year's paper offered twelve questions, from which candidates were required to attempt three. Nine candidates sat the exam. The most frequently chosen Question was Q6 which was attempted by six candidates. This question asked, "Is caste a product of colonialism, or did it evolve independently over time?" Strong responses to Q6:defined the terms clearly (what counts as "colonial construction," what is meant by independent or long durée evolution). Mapped the historiography, contrasting arguments that emphasise colonial census, law, and missionary ethnography with evidence of precolonial social stratification. They used concrete, regionally specific case studies to show variation across time and place rather than treating "caste" as uniform. They also distinguished between ideology, ritual hierarchy, and material relations (labour, land, and political power), explaining how these interacted. The next most popular was Question 7: "How can 'durable integration' be

understood in the context of South Asia?" Effective answers here: operationalised the concept across multiple dimensions, legal-political (citizenship, representation), economic (labour-market incorporation, earnings stability), social-cultural (associational life, language acquisition, intermarriage), and spatial (segregation vs mixed neighbourhoods). They drew on South Asian examples (e.g., post-Partition migrants, cross-border migration, internal rural–urban migration, and conflict-affected displacement) to show how state capacity, federal arrangements, language policy, and welfare regimes shape outcomes.

Two additional questions, Questions 11 and 12, each attracted three answers. They asked, respectively: "To what extent did the economic reforms of the 1990s reshape the Indian economy?" and "How have affirmative action policies influenced caste in South Asia, and to what extent have they brought about equity?" Robust answers to Q11 typically did the following: set the baseline by outlining the pre-1991 policy regime and the immediate macroeconomic triggers for reform. Identified core reform pillars (industrial de-licensing, trade and tariff liberalisation, financial-sector changes, exchange-rate and fiscal stabilisation, FDI policies) and traced their transmission channels to firms, sectors, and households. They also considered distributional and environmental consequences, state–business relations, and issues such as "jobless growth" or premature deindustrialisation, engaging with counterarguments and alternative explanations (e.g., global cycles). For Question 12 (affirmative action and equity): they clarified the policy instruments (reservations/quotas in education, public employment, and political representation; targeted scholarships and welfare) across relevant South Asian contexts. Distinguished equity of opportunity from equity of outcomes and specified how each would be measured. Addressed debates on design (e.g., creamy-layer criteria, stigmatic labelling, private-sector coverage) and unintended consequences, while comparing quotas with complementary measures (school quality, financial aid, anti-discrimination enforcement). The very best answers to both questions were tightly organised, opened with a clear thesis, justified the selection of empirical material, and delivered a focused, analytical argument throughout.

The overall mark distribution was fairly compact, spanning from high upper-second level to first class, with five candidates achieving over 70%. On the whole, scripts showed solid conceptual grasp, broad engagement with the literature, and strong empirical grounding. Weaker scripts tended to be less comprehensive or loosely structured; stronger ones articulated a coherent (often conceptual) analytical framework and were precise, methodical, empirically rich, critically engaged, nuanced, and wide-ranging in their coverage of scholarship.

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Report on A12728P1 Politics in the Middle East

31 students took this paper (24 in PPE; 7 in History and Politics).

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	8
2	15
3	2
4	19
5	10
6	1
7	10
8	10
9	9
10	0
11	2
12	1

Summary reflections on the paper as a whole

The scripts were generally high quality (average = 68; std. dev = 3.5). There was a high degree of agreement between first and second markers. Students clearly preferred some questions over others. The most popular questions related to political Islam and elections, oil and the rentier state, the outbreak of mass protest and the Arab Spring, coup-proofing, clientelism and uncompetitive elections, and gender quotas. By contrast, students were much less likely to tackle questions related to other dimensions of political economy (Q11 on the labour market), the legacies of the Arab Spring on political preferences (Q10), attitudes to refugees (Q6), and welfare politics (Q3)

Report on A12729P1 International Relations in the Era of Two World Wars

6 students took this paper

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	**5**
2	**3**
3	**1**
4	**1**
5	**3**
6	**0**
7	**2**
8	**1**
9	**0**
10	**0**
11	**1**
12	**1**

There were originally seven candidates for the paper, but one withdrew. The quality of scripts was generally high, with three of the six achieving marks of 70 or over for the paper, two of which were exceptionally strong and received marks in the high 70s. The rest of the marks were in the 60-70 range.

With such small numbers taking the paper it is hard to comment on individual questions, other than to note that the most popular question was Q1: 'Did Germany Start World War One'. Nearly all the candidates attempted the question, and some answers were extremely strong demonstrating both deep historical knowledge and the ability to reflect at a more abstract level on the question of responsibility for the outbreak of the war.

Report on A12730P1 International Relations in the Era of the Cold War

22 students took this paper.

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	10
2	8
3	12
4	12
5	1
6	5
7	1
8	4
9	2
10	2
11	5
12	1

Fair batch of essays with some strong answers. Main difference between strong and weak answers came down to the specificity with which historical material and secondary literature were discussed. Weaker answers relied implicitly on lecture content for argument and structure and only could refer to historical facts in general terms with no or very little reference to literature. Stronger essays were able to draw on more specific details from historical events and/or secondary literature. Strongest essays were able to discuss nuance within literature and address scholarly debates.

Brief remarks on individual questions

Please note the number of students answering the question, the overall quality of answers, notable weaknesses in the answers (and/or question) and anything else worth reporting and learning from (including suggested actions).

There is clear clustering of essays for questions related to Great Power dynamics, particularly regarding the questions of origin and endings. Students also tended to answer questions that were covered during lectures as opposed to tutorial topics. (Below are more specific comments, limited to questions with >2 responses)

Q1: Strong answers had a clear grasp of key events/facts, such as the Yalta/Potsdam conferences, Marshall Plan, Berlin Blockade, Korean War.

Q2: Strong answers were able to draw on specific examples from history of the impact of containment.

Q3: Popular question, stronger answers presented clear definitional discussion on what détente was, and strongest answers grappled with what 'resulted' from the policy in analytically interesting ways.

Q4: Popular question, stronger answers presented more detailed knowledge of the causes of the dissolution of the Soviet Union and internal politics.

Q6: Generally strong answers, but some weaker answers did not clearly address the question (which focused on the impact of decolonisation on the Cold War, not vice versa).

Q8: Generally strong answers, essays that were stronger drew on specific historical examples.

Q11: Interesting batch of answers which showed critical understandings of the notion of 'winning'.

Report on A12731P1 International Relations

1. A popular question, with the best answers combining an analysis of post-1990 events with a critical examination of the limits and shortcomings of classical approaches. The weaker answers showed some confusion in distinguising the approaches from each other, and many also failed to offer clear accounts of the English school, concentrating exclusively on realism and liberalism.

2. There were not many answers to this question: the best gave a clear exposition of international law in terms of its origins, institutions and processes, and related this analysis to the broader theoretical frameworks of IR; they also discussed the criteria for evaluating its effectiveness. The weaker answers gave a limited range of examples and simply reproduced basic definitions of international law.

3. There were not many answers to this question; the best efforts showed good knowledge of specific approaches (most notably feminism) and discussed how ideology could be a source of both strength and weakness. However there was a general lack of post-1990 empirical material in the answers.

4. There were not many answers to this question; the most compelling ones showed a clear understanding of constructivism and used the approach to discuss norms as well as specific state identities (and identity shifts) in the post-1990 era. The weaker answers lacked empirical illustrations and in some instances did not have a clear understanding of the basic features of constructivism.

5. There were some answers to this question; the best ones critically unpacked the concept of hierarchy and explored its different possible dimensions, and also engaged with the classical notion of anarchy. The weaker answers did not provide enough post-1990 examples and essentially gave a thin theoretical summary of postcolonial approaches.

6. A popular question, with the best answers attempting to answer the question and showing an excellent command of the literature while providing a range of empirical examples. The weaker answers did not really address the question, and offered only a small number of examples.

7. There were not many answers to this question. The strong answers referred to the different range of views about globalisation in the literature, and evaluated the question in light of their analyses. The weakers responses were superficial, lacking in empirical detail and often failed to provide a coherent structure to their answers.

8. A popular question, with the best answers attempting to answer the question and showing an excellent command of the literature on democratic peace while providing a decent range of empirical examples. The weaker answers simply gave a standard summary of DPT and tacked a conclusion at the end.

9. There were not many answers to this question, but in overall terms the standard of the answers was high, showing a good grasp of the literature and discussing the different types of conflict which have emerged since 1990, and whether they are really new.

10. A popular question, with generally solid and well-informed answers about the UN's role as a norm-provider. The best answers showed detailed knowledge of the operation of UN agencies (and notably peacekeeping operations), while the weak ones simply recycled standard textbook summaries.

11. There were not many answers to this question, but they were generally of a good standard, with a clear understanding of ethnic conflict and a range of empirical examples; the best answers critically interrogated the concept of ethnicity itself, while the weaker ones stayed with a small cluster of examples (typically the former Yugoslavia and Rwanda).

12. There were not many answers to this question, but the efforts were quite impressive, combining a clear understanding of the culture-as-conflict literature and attempting to relate it to the wars in Ukraine and Gaza. The weaker answers either only discussed the literature without the two cases, or only wrote about the cases without connecting them to the literature.

In overall terms the standard of the answers was very solid, with some exceptionally good scripts at the top end, a large swathe of decent answers in the middle, and a relatively short tail. The best scripts combined conceptual sophistication with empirical depth and range, and also demonstrated a capacity to connect the material they had learned to current events (in Ukraine and Gaza for example). The worst scripts were thin on all these fronts, and/or reproduced generic material (notably on democratic peace and the UN). There was the usual clustering of answers around some core topics.

Report on A12732P1 Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau

16 candidates took this exam.

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	0
2	4
3	2
4	2
5	1
6	9
7	10
8	6
9	0
10	8
11	1
12	5

The overall quality of the exam scripts was adequate, with three first-class performances. While questions concerning Machiavelli, Hobbes, and Rousseau were popular, the overall distribution of responses was encouraging. More candidates attempted the 'theme' questions than in previous years, and only two questions received no responses (a thematic question on democracy and a question concerning Hume). Questions concerning Plato and Aristotle were decidedly less popular than in previous years. This is perhaps attributable to the specificity of the exam questions. The best exam scripts defended a clear argument that directly addressed the exam question. These scripts engaged with the primary text(s), historical context, and relevant scholarly literature. They also entertained objections, were alert to textual ambiguities and subtleties, and proposed original interpretations of the authors and themes under discussion. Weaker exam scripts often succumbed to rote summary of the primary text(s). These scripts often failed to adequately consider the motivation for the exam question or present a sustained argument. When considered overall, some scripts were uneven in length and depth (for example, some scripts provided an almost two-thousand-word response to one question but a seven-hundred-word response to others).

1. To what extent is democracy defined by its use of a specific decision procedure? Answer with reference to at least TWO authors.

No responses.

2. Does Thrasymachus provide a coherent account of justice at Republic I?

A classic and much debated topic in the scholarly literature on Plato's *Republic*. As noted above, fewer candidates answered the question concerning Plato than in previous years. This is perhaps attributable to the specificity of the question. The best exam scripts scrutinised the consistency of Thrasymachus's three definitions of justice. Weaker scripts failed to adequately address textual material from Book I and relied upon material from other

books to sustain their arguments. Some scripts identified Thrasymachus's definitions of justice with popular Greek conceptions of morality (see K. Dover).

3. What does Aristotle mean when he says that 'a wife is ruled in a political way' (Politics, I.12)?

The stronger of the two exam scripts considered what the term 'political' might mean in this context, drawing comparisons to other uses of the term in book one and book three. The script also considered how 'marital rule' ought to be differentiated from 'political rule' and 'despotic rule.'

4. For Aquinas, what makes natural law *natural*?

Both scripts considered how natural law may be natural on account of our nature as human-beings. The better script scrutinised what human nature consisted of, the political implications of that nature, and how human nature compared to the nature of god. This script departed from lecture materials and proffered an original interpretation.

5. To what extent does *Utopia* describe a society where the citizens are happy?

Too few responses for comment.

6. Is Machiavelli a consequentialist?

A popular exam question. Several candidates struggled to define the term 'consequentialist', falsely assuming that all consequentialists are hedonists or utilitarians. Others failed to pay sufficient attention to the subtlety of Machiavelli's language or his examples. It seems reasonable to conclude that Machiavelli's aim is to *re-define* the traditional Christian virtues just as much as it is to reject those virtues. The best exam scripts considered textual evidence from both *The Prince* and *Discourses,* as well as relevant context from Cicero's *de Officiis.*

7. 'Hobbes was at any rate more candid: he did not pretend that a sovereign does not enslave: he justified this slavery, but at least did not have the effrontery to call it freedom' (ISAIAH BERLIN). Do you agree?

The most popular exam question. The best exam scripts considered how Hobbes might respond to Berlin's argument given its similarity to the arguments of Hobbes's republican opponents. Such scripts also scrutinised the details of Hobbes's conception of liberty (specifically, his distinction between liberty *qua* body and liberty *qua* subject). Further, several scripts considered how Hobbes's idea of representation may have motivated Berlin's interpretation. Some scripts incorporated points from Hobbes's historical context to great effect. The weakest scripts simply accepted Berlin's characterisation of Hobbes' argument with little substantive engagement.

8. 'Locke fails to see that prerogative power is the power of an arbitrary will.' Discuss.

Several exam scripts dismissed the premiss of the question or considered the apparent tension between Locke's republicanism and his endorsement of prerogative power easily resolvable (closer attention to the interpretations of H. Dawson and Q. Skinner would have disabused candidates of this presumption). The best exam scripts considered how Locke's

remarks on prerogative power compared with his other remarks on liberty, natural law, and the common good. Some scripts incorporated points from Locke's historical context to great effect.

9. Are Hume's arguments against tacit consent successful?

No responses.

10. According to Rousseau, what is the general will?

A deceptively simple exam question that separated the wheat from the chaff. Several scripts failed to differentiate between competing interpretations of the general will (for example, procedural and substantive interpretations) or defend a version of one interpretation against reasonable objections from another. Other scripts failed to interrogate how Rousseau's comments on the general will are informed by his views on goodness, liberty, and justice. The weakest scripts simply collected and summarised Rousseau's various statements without providing a coherent interpretation. A few excellent scripts considered the general will in light of remarks from other texts in Rousseau's *corpus*.

11. Is a mixed constitution a good constitution? Answer with reference to at least TWO authors.

Too few responses for comment.

12. To what extent can appeals to human nature justify the foundation of the state?

A broad, thematic question that could be approached from a variety of different perspectives. Several candidates marshalled premisses from Plato, Aristotle, Hobbes, and Rousseau. Some scripts interpreted the question in light of previous exam questions (for example, whether an author is optimistic or pessimistic about human nature). The best scripts considered whether a particular premiss really justified a particular conclusion about the state or political community (for example, perhaps Plato's premiss that an agent ought to practice one work in the political community does not substantiate a division of rule). Too often scripts summarised an author's views on human nature without considering those views critically. Further, several scripts failed to recall relevant textual details or examples.

Report on A12733P1 Political Thought: Bentham to Weber

Paper sat by 16 candidates.

General Comments:

There was a reasonable spread of answers across the paper, with only one question – on science 'replacing' religion in the nineteenth century – failing to attract any takers. Taken as a whole, the knowledge of the views of the prescribed authors was good, although familiarity with the primary texts was not always well conveyed. The main discriminating factors between candidates remains their ability to use what they know in order to answer the precise question asked. The very best scripts, in addition to those exam skills, also typically demonstrate analytical sophistication and some independent critical judgment. Finally, students taking this paper are strongly encouraged to attend, and make good use of, the lectures provided for this course.

Question 1. In what ways, if any, can Saint-Simon's thought be considered 'socialist'?
This was the most popular question on the paper this year, and there was some good knowledge of Saint-Simon's views on display. Many of the better essays traced multiple reasons both for and against considering his views 'socialist', before arguing a case on the balance of that complex evidence. Accounts of what 'socialism' might be varied considerably, both in content and quality.

Question 2. Can Bentham's utilitarianism be read as an expression of 'late' Enlightenment thought?

There was plenty of good knowledge of Bentham's ideas amongst candidates, but some struggled with what the term '"late" Enlightenment thought' might mean. As ever, candidates should attempt to define technical, and quasi-technical terms in the question, even if they are not as confident about their meaning as they would like to be. An imperfect definition is nearly always better than no definition at all.

Question 3. Why is Tocqueville both pessimistic and optimistic about the prospects for democracy?

This was a very popular question. And there was some good general understanding of Tocqueville's views demonstrated (for instance, regarding differences between the two volumes of Democracy in America). However, some scripts might have benefitted from greater reflection on the causes (and not just the content) of Tocqueville's 'pessimistic' and 'optimistic' alternatives (in order to explain why he was, at different points and in different contexts, pessimistic and optimistic).

Question 4. Do Mill's views on colonial policy compromise his commitment to liberty?

This was a very popular question. Basic understanding of Mill is of a good level amongst candidates, but there was much variety in the knowledge marshalled in answering this precise question. Some candidates perhaps relied too much on Mill's remarks on 'barbarians' in On Liberty, whereas others were able to use a much wider range of material from Mill's life (his career in the East India Company) and writings (his response to the 'atrocities' committed by Governor Eyre in Jamaica, for instance). There was some good knowledge of, and engagement with, the growing secondary literature on this topic.

Question 5. How does Hegel model the relationship between history and freedom?

Hegel is not an easy author, and it is good to see candidates attempting to get to grips with his ideas. Given the number of answers to this question generalisations are difficult. However, the dual structure of his account of freedom – its having 'objective' and 'subjective' threads – was perhaps not always sufficiently emphasised.

Question 6. Is Marx's view of history teleological?

Many answers displayed a reasonably good understanding of Marx's theory of history, but some of them struggled to relate this understanding to the precise question asked. In particular, not all answers provided a very clear or accurate account of what a 'teleological' theory of history might be. As ever, better answers attempt to define the technical and quasi-technical terms that appear in the question, and use those definitions in their overall argument.

Question 7. What is the link between Weber's scientific and political views?

Not a very popular question, and generalisations are difficult. Candidates typically perhaps had more to say about the content of Weber's scientific and political views, than about the relation between them.

Question 8. What solutions does Durkheim offer in response to the problems of the division of labour?

Not a very popular question, and generalisations are accordingly difficult. However, it is worth reminding future candidates that Durkheim's Professional Ethics and Civil Morals is also a prescribed text for the Bentham to Weber paper. It is not easy to answer this question well on the basis of The Division of Labour alone.

Question 9. 'It was science, not politics, that replaced religion in the nineteenth century.' Discuss with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.

Too few answers to comment on.

Question 10. ‘The nineteenth century witnessed the discovery of the social as an object of inquiry.’ Discuss with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.

Too few answers to comment on.

Question 11. Did nineteenth-century political thinkers welcome or fear the rise of the individual? Answer with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.

Not a very popular question, and generalisations are accordingly difficult. However, it is worth observing that the selection of authors in these thematic questions is important; that some comparisons are likely to be much clearer and more productive than others.

Question12. ‘The degree of female emancipation is the natural measure of general emancipation.’ Discuss with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.

Not a very popular question, and generalisations are accordingly difficult. However, it is worth repeating that the selection of authors in these thematic questions is important; that some comparisons are likely to be much clearer and more productive than others.

Report on A12734P1 Marx and Marxism

Paper sat by 11 candidates.

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	4
2	3
3	7
4	8
5	1
6	4
7	1
8	3
9	3
10	1
11	0
12	0

A robust yet not overly spectacular batch of papers, with striking uniformity in their choice of questions: leaning towards Hegel for the questions on individual thinkers, mostly on questions of democracy for the combinatory second half of questions. The uneven distribution of difficulty between questions — the one on Tocqueville was hardly as challenging as the broader one on Hegel — nonetheless left little mark on students' own preference, who regularly went for the more demanding tasks. Some answers showed the marks of lengthy tutorial engagements with the thinkers in question, which implied better knowledge of the primary, while only a rare number properly involved secondary literature in their essays. Even if most pieces' grounding in the primary was reliable, a deeper involvement of secondary thinkers — say, schools of Hegel-interpretation or different Marx-readings — would have increased the overall median for the papers in question.

1. In what ways, if any, can Saint-Simon be considered 'the first social scientist'?

Despite the awkward placing in the syllabus, this question was chosen with surprising frequency, often used to thematise larger questions within the syllabus. The quality of the answers varied downwards — some stuck to biographical details and generalities without truly addressing the analytical task at hand, others were referenced secondary literature to showcase their knowledge of both Saint-Simon and his readers. All in all, very few of the answers were able to provide a sharply targeted reply to the question itself.

2. 'Bentham is one of the most exemplary inventors of technologies of power.' (MICHEL FOUCAULT) Discuss.

A question which directly involves a secondary assessment of the thinker in question, which required knowledge beyond mere primary texts. Most answers took Foucault's reply at face value and mounted only a cursory defence of Bentham against the accusation, to then vindicate the former's reading of the latter. Some were able to refer Foucault's broader historical assessment in 'Discipline and Punish', which gave broader context to his assessment, but references to Bentham's own thought were a bit scarce.

3. Why did Hegel believe that history had meaning?

Of all the questions on individual thinkers, this surely was one of the most challenging, but it was also chosen with remarkable consistency across different papers. The range of answers ran from sophisticated, furnished with extensive reference to different schools of Hegel-interpretation (Berlin, Pippin), to the more superficially descriptive, with at times assertive references to the primary which were difficult to make sense of within the corpus of Hegel's own writings. The concision of the question therefore did not deter and had the benefit of inviting some shrewd answers too.

4. Is Marx's project better conceived as social science or as political theory?

A question on a primary thinker nonetheless hard to answer without reference to the sizeable secondary literature, implying a capacity to sift through different 'marxological' schools. Some answers were able to make the due references; others stuck to a more conventional and thereby limited approach by providing political context about Marx's career as an activist rather than a detached thinker. Some essays had an impressively expansive answer to the question, tying together intellectual, political, and social-historical factors.

5. 'In the end, Tocqueville was an aristocratic liberal.' Discuss.

Perhaps unsurprisingly, answers for this question focused more heavily on the noun than on the adjective in the description: trying to establish the purported liberalism of Tocqueville's thought is more important than the biographical factum that he was of aristocratic descent (even if the adjective could be interpreted differently, in a more plainly ideological sense). Some answers swerved towards discussion of his attitude towards democracy, which was taken as a (not illogical) proxy for his presumed liberalism, which opened a can of further terminological worms.

6. Can Mill's liberalism reasonably count as utilitarian?

This was one of the most intuitive questions in the batch, mostly answered with reference to Mill's own thoughts on his declared neo-utilitarianism — and which inevitably required an independent assessment by the candidate itself, which pushed the task beyond the purely descriptive and into the analytical (or even normative). Some were able to use secondary to construct their own answer to the question, even if they could remain evasive and lose sight of some of the central issues at hand.

7. Was Weber a proponent or opponent of Caesarist modes of rule?

A question only rarely chosen, with the existing answer holding the right balance between the textual and the contextual (mostly with reference to the 'Vocation' lectures, and some slight discussion of Weber's role in the drafting of the Weimar-constitution and his assessment of the post-war situation). The answers rightly pointed at his plea for a controlled Bonapartism, and its connection to broader geopolitical concerns and *Weltpolitik* (which could have received slightly stronger emphasis here).

8. How should the role of corporations in Durkheim's social theory best be conceived?

The answers to this less popular question usually focused on Durkheim's writings on the division of labour, here only faintly related to his broader thought on sociological method.

They used a rather constrained set of texts which could have done with some diversification in terms of sources, but overall, they were able to accomplish their task within these bounds.

9. ‘Every 19th-century political thinker sought to supplant religion as an organising social force.’ Discuss with reference to at least TWO authors.

The most rewarding of all the combined question, usually answered with reference to Marx or Saint-Simon (and even with a sprinkle of Hegel). Most ably teased out the shared theme of secularisation from both writings, even if the connection was not always as visible as it should be — an invitation to discussion sufficed for these questions, however, which made them the most pleasant to mark.

10. Was 19th-century liberalism necessarily hostile to democracy? Answer with reference to at least TWO authors.

A question with a predictable range of references — from Mill to Tocqueville, while Marx and Hegel are much more difficult to fit — which usually elicited decent answers, sometimes complemented by a useful reference to Weber, whose liberalism is seen as finally reconciling both traditions through a Bonapartist ploy. The questions sometimes had difficulty conceptually pinning down the tradition in question (who exactly counts as a ‘liberal’ here?) but this did not obstruct capable answers.

11. ‘The critique of capitalism was by no means a socialist prerogative in the 19th century.’ Discuss with reference to at least TWO authors.

To my knowledge, no candidate opted for said question.

12. ‘In the 19th century feminism entailed socialism, just as socialism entailed feminism.’ Discuss with reference to at least TWO authors.

To my knowledge, no candidate opted for said question.

Report on A12735P1 Sociological Theory

Only seven candidates took this paper, including one who sat a bespoke examination paper under special conditions. The quality of scripts varied greatly. One script failed. Another, sadly let down by one very short answer, was classified in the lower division of the second class. Two scripts were in the upper division, while three were first class.

From the standard examination paper, Q4 (rational choice and emotions) was the most popular, with four answers. There were three answers each for Q1 (networks and integration) and Q8 (violence and the state). Q2 (ideas), Q9 (signalling), and Q10 (deviance) each attracted two answers, while Q6 (capitalism and evolution) and Q7 (racism) each attracted one. The average number of words per individual answer was approximately 1,300 (excluding the very short answer).

Report on A12737P1 Political Sociology

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	16
2	13
3	7
4	15
5	8
6	15
7	36
8	4
9	28
10	49
11	13
12	45

Eighty-four candidates were entered; eighty-three sat the examination. At the time of reporting, marks were available for 82 candidates. The mean was 64.35. Performance spanned the full range: 21 scripts achieved Distinction (≥70); 46 were in the 60–69 band; 11 in 50–59; 2 in 40–49; 1 was recorded in the pass/probationer band (≤39 under special provisions); and 1 script failed. Overall, the cohort showed strong upper-band performance with a clear concentration in the 60–69 range and a high number of distinctions.

In total, 249 answers were submitted. The distribution of answers reveals clear patterns of student interest. The most frequently attempted question was Q10 (“Are cultural divisions replacing class divides in electoral politics?”), which attracted 49 answers (20% of the total). This was followed by Q12 (“What explains gender gaps in political participation?”) with 45 answers (18%), Q7 (“Can post-materialism explain the rise of right-wing populism?”) with 36 answers (14%), and Q9 (“Does digital media deepen political polarization?”) with 28 answers (11%).

Questions at an intermediate level of popularity included Q1 (“Is secularisation an inevitable consequence of modernisation?”) with 16 answers, Q6 (“Is the relationship between social capital and democracy bidirectional?”) with 15, Q4 (“‘Economic elites, rather than political elites, drive societal concern for climate change.’ Discuss.”) with 15, and Q2 (“Does welfare state expansion lead to greater social equality?”) with 13.

Less frequently attempted were Q11 (“Does globalization erode national identity?”) with 13 answers, Q5 (“‘Voting and protest behaviour are equally irrational forms of political participation.’ Discuss.”) with 8, Q3 (“Is Islamophobia a distinct form of prejudice?”) with 7, and Q8 (“Can there be a unified theory of civil wars and revolutions?”) with only 4.

Overall, the profile of question choice reflects an engagement with contemporary debates on political cleavages, participation, populism, and digital media, while more theoretically abstract or historically framed questions attracted relatively little attention.

Report on A12740P1 Social Policy

29 candidates took this paper.

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	6
2	8
3	12
4	7
5	4
6	9
7	8
8	18
9	5
10	3
11	2
12	5

Overall, the quality of scripts was very high, leading to a relatively compressed distribution of marks. Seven students received first class marks, and the vast majority were in the 2.1 range with many high 2.1s. Answers showed a strong command of the material, displaying clear knowledge of the readings and their broader implications. The best scripts were able to move beyond the core course material to make original arguments or address the questions in novel ways. The typed exam format generally allows longer and more detailed answers than was typical in the past, but some scripts could be improved by clearer planning.

1. Does it make sense to discuss the “goals” or “purposes” of welfare states?

This was a challenging question because success in answering it required clearly defining the core terms and making a strong argument about how we should study the welfare state. Students answered this question successfully in a variety of ways: some took a more historical approach, examining the evolution of goals over time and the analytic value of studying them, while others adopted a more theoretical approach, outlining different perspectives on welfare and interrogating the purpose of studying these perspectives. Weaker answers tended not to define the core terms or to establish clear criteria for evaluating what it means to “make sense.”

2. Which political factors explain the emergence of the three worlds of welfare?

Most answers demonstrated some knowledge of core regime theories, and some engaged carefully and extensively with the “three worlds” perspective. Stronger answers not only engaged with the literature on the emergence of varied welfare states in depth but also applied a critical lens, evaluating the importance of different factors and the logic of variation these theories aim to explain. Weaker answers showed more superficial knowledge of the literature and sometimes omitted core elements of the theories under discussion.

3. Is there good evidence that some welfare mixes produce better outcomes than others?

This was a popular question, and most answers were relatively strong. Many defined the logic of welfare mixes, clarified what constitutes "good evidence," and outlined what "better outcomes" might mean, before turning to a broad analysis of the existing literature on a particular sector (e.g., welfare mixes in health). The strongest answers examined in depth how different constellations of mixes operate together to produce varying outcomes, or else challenged the very possibility of making generalizable claims about mixes given the heterogeneity of experiences. A few essays fell short because they devoted too much time to the conceptual setup with little empirical analysis or engagement with the literature—or vice versa.

4. How and why do immigrant social rights vary across contexts?

Most answers to this question were solid, demonstrating knowledge of a range of literature and engagement with core concepts. Some essays fell short by not clearly defining variation in the core outcome—immigrant social rights—which weakened their analysis. Stronger essays defined immigrant social rights in a variety of ways but generally concentrated on one or two dimensions of variation and then sought to explain them in depth.

5. Do reforms to the NHS over the last two decades constitute a substantial break with its founding principles?

This prompt required students to reflect on the founding principles of the NHS and what constitutes a significant break from them. Many answers extended the period of analysis beyond the last two decades, which was perfectly acceptable so long as they also engaged with more recent reforms. Strong answers took a range of positions on the question but generally established clear evaluative criteria—based on the original founding principles—for assessing change and then traced these criteria through their analysis.

6. What do the contrasting approaches to child poverty since 1997 tell us about the feasibility of eradicating child poverty in modern Britain?

Answers for this question generally showed good knowledge of the literature on poverty and anti-poverty policies, but did not always clearly link them to the actual question. Some essays started out strong, defining terms and the theoretical debates clearly, but showed less knowledge of the UK policy context and thus did not clearly answer the question. Others went through policy details, but with little analytic engagement about their approach. The best answers combined both, a clear framework for thinking about varied approaches to poverty reduction, which they then applied to modern Britain, and brought back to the bigger question at hand.

7. "The primary aim of contemporary UK labour market policy is to force people into work." Discuss.

Most answers to this question were strong. Better answers took on the question about what constitutes a "primary aim", set a benchmark for evaluation, and then made a clear argument about the trajectory of policy. Some answers floundered by not making clear conceptual distinctions, i.e. what does it mean to "force" people in work? Students succeeded with quite different empirical bases. Some focused mostly on the last decade, others reviewed the period from the 1980s to present. The former entailed more detailed analysis of policy, while the latter provided a more general analysis, which traced multiple policies (e.g. minimum wage, work conditional benefits and so on) over time.

8. Has the British education system become more equal over time?

As in past years, this question on education was very popular. In general, the answers were strong. Most candidates did a good job narrowing down the analytic task – defining a clear time period, delimiting the concept of equality – but took different approaches to the empirical sweep. Some focused on one stage of education (e.g. compulsory education), others looked at the system from pre-primary through to university. Most answers focused on developments in England and Wales, while some also pointed to educational developments in Scotland. The best essays defined equality clearly and really evaluated the evidence around it. Some slipped a little between definitions and analysis – for instance, defining equality as an outcome but then focusing almost exclusively on shifts in institutions. Others provided too few details about the actual education system, focusing more on broad developments. However, many essays showed substantial knowledge of both trends in outcomes (e.g. attainment rates, social mobility and so on) and the core shifts in education policy, and brought these together nicely.

9. How has the history of family policy shaped the way childcare services are currently delivered in the UK?

Most answers showed knowledge of the literature. The essay structures were a little weaker on this question than others. Many answers struggled to really define family policy and its connection to childcare services, and thus while demonstrating knowledge, they did not make a strong analytical claim. Some answers were also quite short.

10. Have we witnessed broad cross-national convergence in pension policy reforms in the last decades?

Too few answers to provide systematic feedback. Generally well done.

11. Does the social model of disability provide a clear blueprint for conceptualizing

and enacting disability policy?

Too few answers to provide systematic feedback. Generally well done.

12. Why do some social problems lead to policy while others do not? Discuss with reference to social policy making.

As in previous years, not many responses to this question, but they were generally quite strong and reflective. Better answers really honed in the theoretical work looking to explain why some issues become politicized, and then used a concrete case or set of cases to flesh out the logic.

Report on A12741P1 Comparative Demographic Systems

TBC

Report on A12743P1 Politics in China

24 candidates; 24 in PPE; 0 in History and Politics

Question One: What does the Chinese economic miracle owe to the Mao era and why? (6 answers]

The best answers noted that the Mao era ultimately enabled the rise of a reform coalition led by Deng that was skeptical about the dangers of ideology and facilitated bottom-up experimentation, that when combined with the top-down shift, enabled China to reform its economy quickly. Without refraining from criticism of the Mao era, good answers also noted that there was successful development of institutions from 1949-76 that subsequent leaders were able to capitalise on to spark economic growth and eventually market reform. Weak scripts were unbalanced, either arguing that there were few or no contributions upon which Deng could build in 1978, or that the introduction of market reforms reversed and destroyed the gains of the collective economy.

Question Two: Did Mao have a 'great strategic plan' for the Cultural Revolution, or was it the result of a chain of unintended developments and results? (12 answers]

This was, somewhat surprisingly, the most popular question on this year's exam, and a third of the candidates turned in strong answers that were marked as firsts. There was a wide variety of approaches in answering the question, with the slight majority claiming that Mao's 'great strategic plan' resided in the elimination of his political opponents; the less common, but generally stronger and more nuanced responses noted that if Mao had a plan, it shifted over time, and reflected a plurality of goals, or that it initially conformed to Mao's plan but subsequently fell outside his control. The strongest answer further noted that once control was lost, the form that chaos took was largely the result of a 'chain of unintended developments' stemming from the political culture that Mao had in fact cultivated through the glorification of guerilla warfare and the stress of constant revolution, emphasised through a succession of mass campaigns.

Question Three: In what ways did the 1981 historical resolution lay the ideological groundwork for the post-Mao era? (5 Answers]

Unfortunately, this question did not yield any strong answers. None of the answers engaged with any of the relevant assigned readings.

Question Four: What did the crackdown against the 1989 demonstrations reveal about the Party's intentions for reform-era governance? (6 answers]

This question allowed candidates to engage in an interpretative exercise, but the best responses were not particularly thoughtful. The very weakest answers accepted official justifications for the crackdown uncritically, and at face value; and did not engage with any of the assigned readings.

Question Five: What is the evidence that China's adoption of market reform 'stalled' its eventual democratisation? (10 answers]

The strongest answers focused how the unique sequencing of reform, the regime's growing ability to co-opt dissenters, and the general optimism among large swathes of the population who favoured economic growth over political change made democratization difficult, drawing on a variety of empirical evidence or case material from relevant assigned readings. The weakest answers focused either on a narrow set of (or a single) readings, considered only the arguments concerning timing and sequencing of reform, and did so uncritically.

Question Six: Why has China's reputed 'social volcano' been dismissed as merely a myth, and what is the likelihood of it being overturned in the next four years? (6 answers]

The strongest answers noted that China's reputed 'social volcano' has been dismissed as a 'myth' because, despite rising instability during the reform era, grievances have not yet become a major threat to the Party-state because of the myriad effective ways that elites have developed in order to distract

from, mitigate, and ultimately repress social grievances. Discussion of the concept of the "social volcano" and measures to distract, mitigate and bury discontent cited the appropriate references from the assigned reading list.

Question Seven: How has the role of Chinese state propaganda shifted over the course of the reform era, and why? [5 answers]

The stronger answers considered a wider range of the assigned readings, and examined how the rise of the internet and short video/multimedia content accessible via mobile phone networks have made propaganda more ubiquitous. Stronger answers also detailed the broader range of materials, from "hard" to "soft" propaganda.

Question Eight: Are China's ethnic minorities 'Frankenstein's monsters' (BU LAG), and, if so, what are some of the chief measures the Party-state has implemented to control them? [2 answers]Too few responses to characterise.

Question Nine: Why does feminism pose particular challenges for contemporary Chinese leaders, and what measures have been taken in recent years to manage these? [3 answers] Too few responses to characterise.

Question Ten: What are the chief legacies of the 2019-2020 Hong Kong protests, both in and outside of Hong Kong? [2 answers] Too few responses to characterise

Question Eleven: 11. Recent developments in Taiwan and Hong Kong have only reinforced the idea that both polities are an 'inalienable part of China' in all but name." Do you agree? [10 answers] Another popular question this year. The strongest answers noted that recent developments have reinforced the idea that, in China's view both Hong Kong and Taiwan are 'inalienable parts of China,' reflected in increased efforts to infiltrate the political, cultural and economic development of both polities. However, the responses to this infiltration from both Hong Kong and Taiwan have clarified that this viewpoint is strongly contested and, in fact, recent developments have prompted both polities to attempt to distinguish their identity from the mainland. The stronger responses compared the two cases to demonstrate that the PRC has adopted different methods of infiltration to suit each polity's political circumstances; and that cultural resistance has respectively developed in response to this infiltration, comparing and contrasting the range of responses by citing the relevant assigned class readings.

Question Twelve: To what extent does China's behaviour in Northeast Asia represent its ambitions for an alternative global order? [5 answers]

Stronger responses noted that China's behaviour in Northeast Asia presents a limited representation of its ambitions for an alternative global order, assuming that that is the PRC's ambition. Its strategic decisions regarding North Korea suggests that China sees itself as a friend of currently marginalised states. Further, its approach towards the United States' major allies in the region, especially Japan, demonstrate that China seeks to increase its regional dominance and legitimacy. Both observations can be extrapolated to a wider ambition about an alternative global order in China's image, but we need to remain skeptical of that conclusion as the PRC also presents as supportive of many aspects of the current world order, and simply wants to reshape selectively. Relevant assigned readings were cited in order to probe the views of policy-making elites, on the question of whether China seeks patron-clientelist relations with its neighbours, as opposed to blunt hegemony.

General Comments:

This year answers were spread more than previous years, perhaps in part due to varying levels of exam preparation. Candidates' choices of course also helped to account for the wider spread of marks. Very good

candidates put more of their analytical capacity on display, making excellent use of the assigned readings. Weak candidates fell back on either uncritical recitations of historical chronologies, ideologically motivated accounts, or bland generalisations, accounting for many of the lowest marks.

Report on A12744P1 Politics of the European Union

Distribution of answers:

Q. No	No. of answers
1	2
2	2
3	2
4	5
5	1
6	2
7	0
8	0
9	0
10	0
11	1
12	0

General comments:

Students had to answer 3 out of 12 essay questions; the distribution of the chosen questions suggests a slight tendency to prefer to answers the more historical and institutional aspects of the course (first half of the paper).

The general quality of the scripts was very good. There were no fails. There were 2 passes, although these were comfortably such. There were only 2 distinctions, and only 1 with a very large share in the merit category – going beyond what have been covered in the lectures and the main required texts. Overall, the performance is an improvement compared to the mean results from 2023-24 (57.23 mean).

Generally, the scripts did a good job in summarizing and discussing the literature. They demonstrated an in-depth understanding of the most important debates and how the readings speak to each other. All the scripts showed independent analysis.

Report on A15594P1 Special Subject in Politics: International Security and Conflict

50 candidates took this paper.

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	8
2	20
3	16
4	12
5	27
6	16
7	4
8	5
9	18
10	0
11	8
12	10

The Finals papers on International Security and Conflict overall were of a generally consistent, well-informed and well-constructed quality, with an average mark in the high 2:1 bracket. This is a subject area in which some students have some prior and general knowledge, both of the empirical material and the analytic questions, but this is usually insufficient without some further study to answer questions well. However, this does give students some confidence with the topics and the issues.

The best answers were able to offer not only an answer to the question but some insight into why the question had been asked, what alternative answers looked like, and what kinds of evidence might be brought to bear to support them.

1. Does the concept of 'human security' solve the problems with the concept of

'national security'? (8 answers)

A decent range of answers showing that the question was well understood. The best answers were specific in their insight into which problems were most grave and why, and also gave interesting qualifications to their other arguments showing a rounded and critical understanding of the issues.

2. What is the most important level of analysis for understanding the causes of

interstate war? (20 answers)

This question was popular, in part because it is a long-standing classic and very obviously follows from the discussion in the core reading, which gives a structure to the answer.

Weaker answers did not understand exactly to what the question was referring (perhaps through a lack of understanding of the core material) and interpreted it in non-specific ways. Better answers were able to challenge the parameters of the question including the notion of identifying a 'cause' in any particular instance of interstate war.

3. How important is inequality as a cause of civil war? (16 answers)

Another reasonably popular question, which on the whole was competently answered. The better answers had interesting and relevant illustrative material from a range of cases and studies to support a complex and considered answer. Weaker answers churned through the literature without attempting to really synthesise an answer or evaluate the scholarship.

4. 'Hearts and minds are fundamental to winning asymmetric wars'. Discuss. (12 answers)

A decent range of answers to this question. The best answers were able to able to dissect what 'winning' could really mean in such circumstances, and consider a range of interpretations of which 'hearts and minds' were at stake and why. Other answers focused more on the place of 'hearts and minds' in counterinsurgency doctrine and showed a good grasp of its general significance in that context.

5. To what extent are mass atrocities strategically motivated? (27 answers)

A very popular question, reflecting in part most likely the interest in the question, the quality of the lecture and the ease of fit with the assigned reading. All students understood the range of motivations at work in the commission of mass atrocities and the literature identifying different factors. Better answers were able to analytically distinguish between different kinds of actors and their motivations, and indeed the difficulty of post hoc rationalisations of violent action, and were able to draw on a wider range of case material than the more widely covered ones (e.g. Rwanda).

6. Are nuclear weapons more important as instruments of deterrence or as symbols of status? (16 answers)

There were many reasonable answers to this question that gave a 'normal' answer to this question, reflecting on the strengths and weaknesses of deterrence theory. The better answers were able to qualify or sophisticate the answers by further specifying which kinds of states in which kinds of moments pursued which kinds of weapons, and their evolving importance in different contexts.

7. Do regional security arrangements empower small states? (4 answers)

Very few answers to this question, one of which was outstanding. The outstanding answer was highly precise and subtle in terms of its understanding of the mechanisms and the

range of case material that was brought to bear on the answer, which went well beyond the core reading. It showed a high level of synthesis of the material. Other less successful answers were less incisive in terms of their analysis and did not work across the arguments in the literature as well.

8. Do new technologies demand different ways of understanding security threats? (5 answers)

Not many answers to this question, but all who did answer it did quite well. The best answers distinguished different kinds of effects from different kinds of technologies which in turn made different 'demands' on our understanding.

9. To what extent is sexual violence in conflict the product of militarised masculinity? (18 answers)

A popular and on the whole well-answered question. The best answers were able to synthesise the standard literature quite quickly and work across different theoretical and empirical levels, making analytically precise points about militarisation and its relationship to masculinity.

10. Has the recent success of counterpiracy efforts resulted from organisational innovation? (0 answers)

11. Do refugees represent a security threat to host countries? (8 answers)

This question asked candidates to respond to one of the major contentions in the literature and was on the whole done well. At least one outstanding answer offered a strong critique that included a methodological as well as empirical qualification to the major work, and a good synthesis of the wider literature and cases.

12. How does peacekeeping keep peace? (10 answers)

This question had a wider variation in answer quality. The best answers were able to not only specify mechanisms and pathways through which peacekeeping might or might not happen, but were also able to interrogate the notion of 'peace' and metrics of success for these operations. The less successful answers synthesised the literature less successfully and in some cases were too capacious with the scope of the answer.

Report on A15601P1 Advanced Papers in Theories of Justice

21 candidates took this paper.

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	0
2	13
3	10
4	7
5	8
6	4
7	3
8	7
9	4
10	5
11	0
12	2

The general standard of the scripts was once again high. 7 candidates received marks above 70, 11 marks of 60-69, and 3 marks below 60. Candidates for this paper tend to be very knowledgeable about the literature. This is obviously a good thing, but it can sometimes lead to essays that mention many different arguments from the literature too quickly, such that the essay lacks analytical depth. As always, the highest marks went to those who were able to use the literature to develop their own focused responses to the specific questions. The most popular topics were again migration, environmental justice, and intergenerational justice. Trade continues to be less popular, with no answers this year, as do the questions that are not topic-specific.

Question 1. Is justice in trade concerned with the relations between the trading parties or the distribution of benefits and burdens between them? (0 answers)

No answers.

Question 2. Must one choose between endorsing states' rights to self-determination and individuals' rights to international freedom of movement? (13 answers)

The most popular question, answered by 62% of candidates. All candidates were able to articulate the conflict suggested in the question. Weaker essays tended not to move much beyond this, or simply recounted the standard debate. Stronger essays considered ways that one might reinterpret the relevant concepts in ways that removed or mitigated the tension between them, or argued that one of the concepts should be rejected such that there is no longer a choice to be made.

Question 3. What role, if any, should the 'ability to pay principle' play in our account of the just distribution of the costs of climate change? (10 answers)

The second most popular question (48% of candidates). Many candidates fell into the trap of simply recounting the debates concerning the PPP, APP, and BPP. Better essays had a clear sense of which aspects of that debate were relevant to the specific argument the candidate was making regarding the role of APP.

Question 4. Is the original position a helpful device when theorising about duties to future generations? (7 answers)

Quite a range of answers. Some were rather limited to points covered in the lecture, and some reflected misunderstandings of Rawls's position (and one or two surprisingly no mention of Rawls at all). But stronger answers showed a sophisticated understanding of both the normative and methodological issues.

Question 5. To what extent can appropriate levels and forms of reparations be determined through normative theorising, as opposed to actual political processes? (8 answers)

A challenging question. Some candidates struggled to clearly articulate what might be meant by 'actual political processes' and what role they might play, especially in relation the specific question of determining the appropriate levels and forms of reparations. Better essays offered thoughtful reflections on this issue, and on both the strengths and limits of normative theorising in this regard.

Question 6. Can there be a duty to give up holdings rooted in historic injustice even when no one else has a right to those holdings? (4 answers)

This question was generally not so well answered. Essays tended to offer general discussions of rectifying historic injustice, rather than focusing on the specific issue suggested in the question.

Question 7. Can we theorise about what disability is independently of theorising about what those with a disability are owed? (3 answers)

Too few answers for comment.

Question 8. 'Parents are permitted to shape their children's values as long as this does not undermine those children's ability to make autonomous choices as adults.' Discuss. (7 answers)

Answers to this question were generally high quality. Candidates showed a good understanding of relevant literature and defended sophisticated and nuanced positions

regarding the limits that future autonomy does or doesn't place on parental value-shaping. Some essays also included good defences or critiques of other limits that would make the view suggested in the question too permissive.

Question 9. Under what conditions, if any, does justice permit denying healthcare to those with serious medical needs? (4 answers)

Candidates showed good knowledge of a range of perspectives on justice in health and healthcare, but some struggled to apply these to the specific question. Better essays recognised various cases where we might consider denying healthcare and carefully considered whether this could in fact be justified.

Question 10. 'Universal basic income might be justifiable under more ideal conditions, but under present non-ideal conditions it would create additional injustice.' Discuss. (5 answers)

Most candidates thought that UBI was in fact *more* justifiable under non-ideal conditions. Weaker essays defended that view without considering any reasons why one might adopt the position suggested in the question, while better essays did consider such reasons, even if they ultimately rejected them.

Question 11. 'Since not all moral reasons are reasons of justice, we should not be concerned if theories of justice cannot fully address some of the issues studied in this paper.' Discuss. (0 answers)

No answers.

Question 12. Can justice within particular policy areas be understood independently of a general account of justice? (2 answers)

Too few answers for comment.

Report on A17325P1 Comparative Political Economy

24 candidates took this paper.

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	16
2	7
3	2
4	7
5	9
6	8
7	2
8	4
9	2
10	10
11	-
12	2

Summary reflections on the paper as a whole

Students spread themselves across a good range of questions, though some were much more popular than others. Question 1 was by far the most frequently attempted, while Questions 2, 4, 5, 6, and 10 also attracted a fair number of answers. A few questions were only chosen by small groups (notably Questions 3, 7, 8, 9, and 12), and Question 11 was not attempted at all. The uneven uptake suggests that some questions were either seen as too difficult or, more likely, students prepared only specific topics.

The overall quality was solid, with a large concentration of competent, Upper Second Level answers. Stronger scripts demonstrated a good grasp of the literature, structured arguments, and engagement with both theory and empirical evidence. Excellent essays stood out for their independence of thought and clarity of argumentation. Weaker answers tended to be descriptive, under-theorised, or poorly structured. In a few cases, scripts were incomplete or made little attempt to address the question directly.

Generally, many answers would have benefited from wider reading and closer engagement with the lecture materials, which provide the essential conceptual foundations for addressing the questions in a structured manner while also creating space for independent argumentation.

Question 1: 'Any attempts by governments to equalize incomes will ultimately reduce national incomes?' How convincing do you find this claim both theoretically and in terms of how well it matches empirical evidence? [16]

This was one of the most popular questions, with a wide range of results. Strong essays demonstrated a clear grasp of the theoretical debate on the trade-off between efficiency and equality, presented well-structured, critical discussions by drawing on relevant literature, and referred to empirical evidence to back their argumentation.

Many more competent answers displayed a solid understanding but often lacked independence of argument, structure, or depth of empirical engagement. A substantial minority of weaker responses were highly superficial or which suggested serious misunderstanding or inadequate preparation.

Question 2: What is the most convincing explanation for why we observe different welfare state regimes? [7]

This question drew a moderate number of responses. The best answers clearly differentiated between welfare state emergence and differences in regime types. They introduced key debates around power-resources, class-coalitions and varieties of capitalism.

Weaker answers had a poor understanding of what a welfare state regime is, how emergence conceptually differs from variation and didn't link the answer to the most relevant theoretical approaches.

Question 3: 'Redistribution is insurance.' Discuss with relation to political economy models connecting inequality to preferences.[2]

Only few students attempted the question, with adequate success. Competent scripts understand the framing of redistribution as insurance and link it to Meltzer–Richard and related models. However, the exam essays did not fully grasp the conceptual frameworks and produced vague discussions.

Question 4: Is the political economy of redistribution better understood as emerging from material self-interested preferences or from identity considerations? [7]

This was a moderately popular choice, with a few very strong scripts demonstrating excellent command of the literature and good argumentation on why material-self interest might trump identity considerations. More common were answers that demonstrated good knowledge of the literature but sometimes lacked conceptual clarity or independent argument. Several weaker scripts revealed confusion about the use of identity, sometimes conflating income with class identity.

Question 5: 'Political institutions work to reduce government accountability for outcomes.' Discuss. [9]

This was a fairly popular question with moderate variation in marks. The best essays clearly analysed mechanisms of how political institutions provide or diffuse accountability by voters, focusing on constitutional setups, electoral systems and the media. Many competent scripts displayed a good grasp of the literature but lacked independence of argument or sharper structure. Weaker answers tended to be basic, descriptive, or lacking in explanation.

Question 6: How can we explain trade preferences? [8]

This question produced a very wide range of results, with a few excellent essays, demonstrating command of the most relevant explanations related to economic and cultural factors as well as factoral and sectoral. Many more responses were competent but limited, with sound engagement with literature but little independence of argument. A minority of weaker answers revealed poor engagement with relevant material and little reference to core readings.

Question 7: Does the Varieties of Capitalism approach help us explain why some countries are better at responding to economic crises? [2]

There are only few responses to this question, with highly uneven performance. The strong scripts offers an excellent understanding of the VoC approach and assesses it with rgard to crisis responses. The weaker script failed to make this link convincingly and lacked structure and conceptual clarity.

Question 8: 'All Varieties of Capitalism will eventually move towards liberalization.' Discuss. [4]

This question produced mixed results. Some students gave strong answers that engaged thoroughly with the literature but didn't provide independent assessment of the question. Weaker attempts revealed poor structure, limited clarity, or superficial engagement with the question. Overall, the strongest essays were competent but rarely excellent.

Question 9: Which approaches to institutional change are most persuasive when explaining such changes in advanced industrialized democratic economies? [2]

This question was attempted by only a few candidates with rather moderate performance. Where the question was answered properly, the essay covered the literature appropriately, structured the discussion around a clear contrast, and made a plausible case. However, it lacked analytical depth and independent evaluation.

Question 10: Are the rise of the knowledge economy and democratic resilience compatible? [10]

This question generated several strong responses, which provided a well-rounded discussion of the tension between the knowledge economy's potential to strengthen democratic resilience and the countervailing risks posed by rising inequalities. Many more competent answers engaged well with the literature but sometimes lost analytical focus or independence of argument. Weaker answers were opinion-based, unfinished, or lacked proper structure.

Question 11: Are the differences in financial systems that existed across countries in the late twentieth century still relevant today?

No answers.

Question 12: Do all crises lead to similar voter responses? [2]

This question was chosen by few candidates. The stronger essay distinguished clearly between economic and non-economic crises and made convincing arguments about how these differences shape voter responses. The weaker answer, by contrast, tended to be incomplete, lacked structure, or relied on unsupported assertions.

Report on A17606P1 Special Subject in Politics: Feminist Theory

Question Number	Number of Student Answers
1	
2	///
3	
4	////
5	////
6	//
7	//
8	
9	//
10	////
11	/
12	/////
13	//
14	
15	/

Overall, there was a wide range in the quality of answers on this paper. Many candidates showed investment in contemporary debates in feminist theory, and the best responses demonstrated deep engagement with central problems, offering clear and succinct analysis. These stronger papers articulated complex conceptual relationships with precision, reflecting careful preparation and a genuine interest in the material. However, a large number of candidates displayed only a competent grasp of major debates, writing essays that were structured and clear but not especially analytical.

A common pattern was that candidates tended to identify the general topic of the question without attending to its specific conceptual focus. This was evident in questions such as Q1, where candidates often treated exploitation as equivalent to oppression without exploring what exploitation as a distinct concept adds, or in Q5, where many discussed social constructionism without analysing what abolition of the category of woman would actually entail. Similarly, in questions such as Q2 on wages for housework, candidates often described the W4H movement but neglected to analyse the function of demands as political action. Stronger papers recognised the need for targeted examination of distinctions and implications rather than general surveys or summaries of readings.

Another common theme was that candidates often summarised authors effectively but stopped short of critical engagement. For instance, in Q6, many summarised Smith and Mac well but few stronger papers compared their work to figures such as Mackinnon or Dworkin and offered deeper analysis of legal regulation models. Similarly, in Q9, while candidates demonstrated a good understanding of social constructionism, Butler's concept of performativity was often misinterpreted, with some describing the concept as purely discursive, voluntary, or just a 'performance'.

Questions requiring engagement with historical and theoretical tensions also revealed this pattern. In Q4, most candidates stated that capitalism has historically relied on patriarchy but did not explore why that reliance might be contingent rather than necessary, or how patriarchy intersects with white supremacy in shaping capitalist relations. Stronger papers distinguished between historical contingencies and theoretical necessities and showed awareness of Marxist feminist debates on reproductive labour.

Where questions invited reflection on agency, choice, or critique, answers often remained at the level of general claims. For example, Q12 saw many candidates discuss social construction in broad terms without critically analysing what 'real choice' would mean for individuals or political organising Similarly, Q10 responses often rehashed Zheng's argument on yellow fever without independent analysis, whereas stronger papers discussed moral authoritarianism, shaming, and what feminist critique or intervention might entail, drawing on Rubin, Mackinnon, Dworkin, and Willis.

There were also questions that exposed a tendency to treat political practices and strategies as essentially linked to identities, despite critiques – often quite simplistic – of essentialism. For example, in Q7, lesbianism tended to be discussed as an identity rather than as a political or sexual practice, and many answers failed to engage deeply with Rubin's distinction between gender oppression and sexual oppression. This tendency to treat questions as invitations to rehearse readings, rather than analyse implications or conceptual tensions, limited the analytical depth of many papers.

Overall, while most candidates were familiar with the readings, many essays lacked original analysis and tended to reproduce debates rather than develop independent arguments. The best papers paid close attention to what each question was asking, used theoretical material with precision, and thought critically about the broader implications of feminist theory for understanding power, gender, sexuality, and political strategy.

1. To what extent is the concept of exploitation necessary to understand women's subordination in society?

Few candidates answered this question. Many candidates presented a discussion of oppression in respond to this question, often suggesting an equivalence with exploitation. As a result, many candidates presented a detailed analysis of the concepts of exploitation or subordination and how they relate. Papers frequently leaned on Young's analysis of the five faces of oppression. Admittedly, since Young's analysis subsumes exploitation under oppression, many papers proceeded as if a discussion of oppression captures both exploitation and subordination. Overall, discussion differentiated between oppression, exploitation, and subordination.

2. Should feminists today demand wages for housework?

This was a somewhat popular question. Some papers discussed the W4H movement without engaging with the literature, but most candidates referenced at least one of the major writers, although they often seemed to discuss their work in superficial ways. The best papers those that presented a good grasp why women's unpaid labour was central to the production of surplus value and how wages could potentially disrupt capitalism. These papers tended to discuss why women's labour was not considered a form of work under

conditions of capitalism. However, no paper had a good sense of how or why the emergence of capitalism changed the household economy and rendered the home a space of unproductivity. Moreover, no candidate discussed the concept of demands or what demanding does as a political action. The best answers were those that could situate the problem of reproductive labour within the context of neoliberalism today.

3. Do gender-neutral policies support or harm women?

This was not a popular question and few candidates answered it. Candidates showed a good grasp of neutrality as a liberal principle and discussed whether this philosophical orientation was good or bad for women's liberation, frequently turning to the analysis of Iris Young to make the case.

4. Does capitalism require patriarchy?

This was a somewhat popular question to answer. Some candidates did not engage in the literature and so their answers were fairly vague. The better papers engaged with the Marxist feminist debates about labour. It was common for candidates to say that historically capitalism has required patriarchy but that theoretically capitalism did not necessitate patriarchy. To make this argument candidates often turned to the work of Davis to show how capitalism did not require women's subordination but just the existence of reproductive labour – regardless of who performed it. Very few papers analyzed the intersection between patriarchy and white supremacy to make this argument. Moreover, the implications of the differences between the history of actually existing capitalism and the theoretical possibility of a 'pure' capitalism were not explored.

5. Should the abolition of the category of woman be a goal of feminism?

This was a very popular question. Candidates often discussed the question in terms of social constructionism, although the analysis on what this entailed was often quite thin. The better answers discussed what the use of a category is in terms of philosophical reflection or political organizing. Unfortunately, no paper discussed what abolition meant or what it entailed.

6. "When sex workers assert that sex work is work, we are saying that we need rights. We are not saying that work is good or fun, or even harmless, nor that it has fundamental

value.... You don't have to like your job to want to keep it." (SMITH and MAC) Do you agree?

This was a very popular question. Candidates often presented a good summary and account of Smith and Mac's position. This question presented the most variation in terms of responses, although it appears that most candidates did agree with the statement. The better papers compared Smith and Mac to the work of Mackinnon, Dworkin, or Overall and also presented an analysis of the different forms of legal regulation possible (criminalization, legalization, and decriminalization).

7. 'Patriarchy is heterosexual. Therefore, lesbianism is a necessary strategy of women's liberation.' Discuss.

Not such a popular question. Candidates discussed lesbianism as identity rather than practice, even though many of the readings on lesbianism specifically discuss it as a sexual-political practice rather than a form of identitarian desire. The papers were quite weak on this question and candidates presented a somewhat caricatured image of 'political lesbianism' without engaging deeply with the literature.

8. "Feminism is the theory of gender oppression. To assume automatically that this makes it the theory of sexual oppression is to fail to distinguish between gender, on the one hand, and erotic desire, on the other." (RUBIN) Discuss.

This was not a very popular question to answer. Many of the papers presented un uncharitable few of Rubin's argument and appeared to have an inadequate grasp of the sex wars debates in which it took place. Many papers answered this question with reference to bdsm as a case study, but did not engage with any of the literature on this topic and often presented a superficial view of the sexual practices that fall under this category.

9. What role should biology play in an account of the social construction of women in order for feminists to be trans-inclusive?

Very popular question. Many candidates displayed a good understanding of what social construction. The better papers discussed social construction in terms of ideas and in terms of objects, often drawing on Haslanger's work. The better papes engaged with objections to the use of biology in feminist theorizing, pointing to the limitations of essentialism, and also the importance of taking biology into account. Unfortunately, many candidates presented a rather skewed interpretation of Butler's ideas of performativity, suggesting that the notion of 'performance' was necessarily anti-trans or that Butler's ideas about social construction were almost entirely discursive.

10. Are there any “problematic” forms of sexual desire? And if so, how should feminists relate to them?

Very popular question. Candidates put aside the question of child sexuality as it were taken for granted as obviously problematic form of desire, even though the literature on sexuality debated this question (e.g. Rubin). Many papers turned to ZHeng’s work n yellow fever, often resahsing the argument as the essay itself, with little independent analysis. The better papers engaged with debates about moral authoritarianism and shaming that were/are present in the feminist movement, and the best ones did so with discussion of Willis, Rubin, Mackinnon, Dworkin. Many candidates took an uncontroversial solution to say that feminists should be self-critical towards desire. It’s uninteresting to say that feminists should simply be reflective. The better papers discussed what critique, of self and others, might entail, specifically discussing the question of state intervention and forms of shaming.

11. Should women’s reproductive labour be treated differently from other forms of labour when it comes to women's oppression?

This was a somewhat popular question. Responses were good but they were fairly repetitive of the debates from the readings, rehashing disagreements in the literature. There was little engagement with Marxist-feminist debates on reproductive labour and capitalism. Few candidates presented originality in their answers, as candidate perspectives were often subsumed in the debates that were presented in the literature.

12. "Feminism must look beyond the right to choose, and ask: Why do we choose what we choose? What would we choose if we had a real choice?" (WILLIS) Discuss.

Popular question. This question seemed to allow for the most diverse use of various authors to answer the question. Better papers spoke about het social construction of choice and the conditions that limit choice. Some candidates presented Willis in caricatured ways, mainly for the purposes of constructing a foil to their own argument. The best papers were those that could construct a debate between authors such as Mackinnon, Dworkin, Willis, and others and critically analyse it. A couple papers were novel in critically analysing the concept of ‘real choice’ and engaging with a discussion of the circumscribed and constrained conditions of agency.

13. How should feminists relate to the state?

Not many candidates answered this question. Candidates presented varied responses to the questions, with most taking a middle ground that feminists should both engage with the state but do so critically, doing so under the category of ‘strategic orientation towards the state’. Unfortunately, there was a general lack of analysis on what is meant when we talk about ‘the state’, whether its institutional formations, or larger theoretical questions such as sovereignty. But good analysis on strategic orientation towards the state.

14. Should feminists seek to abolish the family? Why or why not?

Not many candidates answered this question. Unlike question five, there was more engagement on what the question of abolition meant. The better answers specified that abolition entailed the socialization / democratization of practices of care that are ordinarily privatized in the family. Critiques of the family abolition were somewhat simplistic and under analysed. Candidates turned to Davis to argue that the black family experience (or lack thereof) under slavery meant that the 'the family' was a not a universal model because it differed from white families. The implications of this difference for the question of abolition were rarely interrogated however.

15. "Interpreting female sexuality as an expression of women's agency and autonomy is always denigrating and bizarre and reductive, as if sexism does not exist.... So long as sexual inequality remains unequal and sexual, attempts to value sexuality as women's, possessive as if women possess it, will remain part of limiting women to it, to what women are now defined as being." (MACKINNON) Discuss.

Not many students' candidates discussed this question. The candidates who responded presented a well-rounded account of Mackinnon's work and her criticism of the patriarchal construction of women's autonomy and sexual desire. Very few papers discussed the notion of sexual in/equality indicated by the quote, with the majority focusing on the question of women's agency.